

AND THEN THE DRAGONS
CAME: PUREWATER — THE
AUTHOR'S CUT

Fourth Wall Gaming

PRELUDE

Purewater is built on water and has never pretended otherwise. There is no ground in it worth the name. There are buildings, and there is water, and between the two there are ledges a yard wide with no rail and a drop into traffic that is poled and rowed and shouting at you. Children learn the ledges before they learn their letters. Visitors learn them by falling in.

The city drinks from a channel that comes down out of the lake and runs through the temple on Temple Isle before it runs anywhere else, and the priestesses of the Lake Lady will tell you that the water *is* the goddess, and they do not mean it as a figure of speech, and if you push them on it they will look at you with the particular patience of people who have had this conversation with merchants before.

Once there were Dragon Kings. Everybody knows they are gone. What is left of them is scale-pattern armour on a few border lords, a name on a barony out past the marshes, and a small number of extremely wealthy people who would like the old power back and are prepared to be patient and expensive about getting it.

The Lake Lady's Tourney comes once a year — archery, single combat, and a scramble through the canals for whoever can swim and climb and doesn't mind being laughed at. It is older than the Governor's office and everyone knows that too. For three days the city fills up with strangers and nobody looks closely at anybody, which is very good for trade and has historically been very bad for one or two individual people.

This is an account of three of those days, and a fourth that nobody had planned for.

CHAPTER 1 — THE WOMAN ON THE OTHER SIDE OF THE ROAD



THE MEN CAME IN THE NIGHT WITH FIRE AND STEEL AND THEY DID IT WITH THE particular unhurried savagery that you only ever see from the world of men, and when they had finished they went away again, and Gardwen was eleven years old and alive in a wood with nine people to bury and no one to help her do it.

She counted them in the morning. That is the part she has never told anyone properly, because it does not sound like grief when you say it out loud, it sounds like bookkeeping. But she counted them, all of them, going along the line of what the fire had left, and she counted eight and she counted them again and there were still eight.

Her brother was seven. They had taken him alive and they had taken only him, out of nine people, and they had burned the rest so that nobody would ever be able to do what she had just done and arrive at the number.

She spent a decade after that being the person who hid. That is how she thinks of it. Not the survivor, not the last of them — the one who was small enough to get into a hollow and stay there while it happened. The old ways came to her in that wood and blessed her and taught her to close a wound and read a track and walk through a forest without moving a leaf, and none of it ever once addressed itself to the question of the boy.

Ten years of that colour of scale. She picked it up in four different territories and lost it again every time.

And then, three days ago, she found a column of them on the north road going somewhere at last instead of nowhere, twenty-odd men and a covered litter, and she had followed it here, eating their dust, sleeping when they slept, and she had come out of the trees at the last to find that the road went into a ford and the ford went into a queue and the queue was full of people.

That stopped her.

Ten years in the wilderness will do that. She stood at the edge of the churned mud and looked at forty strangers standing in it, farmers and carters and a family with a goat and three nuns and a troupe of tumblers, and understood with a lurch that she was going to have to stand among them.

She could see how it landed on them. The eyes going and coming back. The mutters. The way the whole queue had quietly arranged itself into a shape with a hole in it where she and the wolf were standing, an eight-foot circle of very polite terror that moved when she moved.

Fine. Let them.

She put her hand into Ruhi's ruff and looked north up the road, where the last of the dragon-scale was going away at a trot, and she made herself think about the litter and not about the people.

Which is when she noticed that one pair of eyes had not gone away.

On the other side of the road, an ancient, tiny woman was straightening up out of the sort of deep crouch that old peasant women rest in. She was cloaked and mud-hemmed and leaning on a staff, and her face was so deeply wrinkled and mottled by the passage of time that it was hard to put a number on her, and she was looking at Gardwen the way you look at a word you know you have read somewhere before.

Gardwen reached out. It cost nothing and she did it without thinking, a small casting she had used a thousand times, a flick of attention at the shape of a stranger's heart —

— and it went into the old woman and hit something like a steel trap and came straight back at her.

She had never had that happen. Not once, in ten years.

The crone was already walking. She came across the mud on the wolf's side, which is the wrong side, which is the side nobody uses, and she did not slow down at twelve feet when Ruhi rose off her haunches and turned to face her square and every conversation within thirty feet stopped.

Gardwen's hand went inside her cloak. Not fast. The way you put a hand on a door latch in a house you don't trust.

The old woman stopped at an arm's length outside what the wolf considered hers. She nodded, once — the nod you'd give a neighbour over a fence — and looked Gardwen straight in the eye, and asked her question like a woman finally getting to the end of something that had been bothering her for years.

"Who are you?"

And Gardwen, who had answers ready for *what do you want* and for *get that animal away from me* and for four or five other things besides, found that she had nothing prepared for that at all.

CHAPTER 2 — THE VOICE OF DEATH HERSELF



MAGDA HAD BEEN PERFECTLY HAPPY BEFORE THE DREAMS STARTED, THANK YOU very much. She was old. She had crops and pigs and a roof that mostly kept the weather where it belonged, and a life that did not, on the whole, involve killing anyone, which after a certain age is the sort of arrangement a woman comes to appreciate.

The dreams were nightmares. They always are. One does not enter into an understanding with the Goddess of Death and then get pleasant dreams about orchards; there is a price for the contact and the price is that some part of the dark is always looking back at you, however brief the visit.

There were three things in it and there were three things every night.

A young woman with a wolf.

A house on fire.

And a knight in dragon-scale who was dead, and walking, and had not been told.

Eleven nights of that, and always the same instruction at the end of it, in a voice like a rusted hinge, under a blasted sky, with dire wolves howling somewhere off in the dark where she couldn't see them:

Lay the dragon warrior to rest.

Not kill. Hel is specific by being unspecific. Hel points, and does not explain, and expects you to do the arithmetic yourself, and if you get it wrong that is apparently also part of the lesson.

Magda had turned it over for three hundred miles and it still would not come apart in her hands.

And there was the other thing, which she would not have admitted to anyone: she was seventy years old and she did not look it, and had not looked it for a very long time, and that was the goddess's doing and not hers. It is a strange kind of blessing that mostly means you outlive everybody you were fond of. She had buried enough people to be extremely clear-eyed about the terms.

So. Three hundred miles, a quarterstaff, a staff sling, fourteen stones and a purse with very little in it, and here she was at a ford outside a city she had last seen twenty years ago, standing in a queue, with no further instructions whatsoever.

And then a young woman came out of the treeline with a wolf.

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Up close, the girl was worse than the dream had suggested. Road-grime worked into the seams of the knuckles and none at all under the nails, which means she washes what she can and has given up on the rest. Thin in the way of someone who eats when there is food rather than when there is hunger. And young — much too young for the flat, patient watchfulness in her face, which is not a thing anybody is born with. Somebody put that there.

"Gardwen," she said, when she was asked. And then, in the voice of a woman who has had this conversation before and expects nothing at all to come of it: "You'll want to be somewhere else, mother. People who stand near me have a poor time of it."

Magda grunted at her. It is not a word. It is the noise you make at a gate that has swollen shut, and it carries about the same amount of argument.

“I’ve been dreaming of you, girl.”

Then she walked past her — past, not at, on the wolf’s side — and put her hand into the fur at the base of the animal’s neck, where the ruff is thickest and a hand goes in to the wrist.

The wolf locked. The whole animal, shoulder to haunch, one decision made at once, and its head came round and its jaw was four inches from Magda’s forearm and its breath was hot on the inside of her wrist.

She did not move her hand. She scratched, down, once, the way you work a burr out.

The rigidity came out of the shoulders first and then the back, and the head turned away, and the animal made a low sound in its chest that no townsman would recognise as anything at all. Up north they would have known it. Up north they would have said the dog had decided you were furniture, and furniture is the highest rank a stranger gets.

“—*don’t*,” Gardwen said, three seconds too late, her hand half out and stopping. “Ruhi doesn’t let people do that.”

“My goddess tells me you’re someone I need to help,” Magda said. “Don’t know why. That’s what she told me.”

“Your goddess.” Slowly. “*Which* one.”

And Magda could hear exactly what the question was. The girl was asking whether this was one of the singing ones. Whether she was about to be told that it had all been for the best.

“Hel,” she said. “Death.” The wolf’s weight settled against her shin. “Not death in battle.” She said it the way you would correct someone about which field the boundary stone is in. “The other kind. Everywhere else. In the bed, in the byre, in the bad winter. The ones nobody sings about.”

Gardwen went very still.

Magda has seen that look before, on people who came expecting to be sold something. It is the look of a bucket that has had the bottom go out of it.

“No,” Gardwen said quietly. “No, that’s — that’s an honest god.”

Then, fast, like a woman pulling a splinter: “Does she show you a boy?”

Her hand had gone into the wolf’s ruff beside Magda’s. She did not appear to have noticed doing it. Her knuckles were white.

There was a beat.

“No,” said Magda. “Not a boy.”

And she did not dress it, because she had delivered enough bad news across enough gates to know that softening it only makes people hear it twice. A knight. Dragon-scale. Dead and standing up and walking and nobody had told him.

She watched the girl’s face do the arithmetic and arrive somewhere else entirely from where it had been sent.

“Dragon Knights,” Gardwen said. Flat. “It’s Dragon Knights you dream of.”

And then Magda knelt down in the mud.

It made a sound like a boot coming out of a bog. It was cold, and it went straight through the wool, and she was seventy years old on the outside and there was nothing dignified about any part of it. Behind her one of the tumblers said something and another one laughed and was hit.

She held the staff out crosswise in both hands, the way it is done, the way her grandmother had done it once to a man who died the following spring.

“I’m to fight for you, girl. Protect you and yours, however you’d ask it. Die for you, if it comes to that.”

Gardwen did not take the staff.

She stood there with her hand in her wolf's fur next to a stranger's hand and her mouth doing something unsteady, and she looked hard at the middle distance, the way people do when they will not do the other thing in public.

"Get up," she said. It came out wrong. "Get *up*. You'll — the ground's freezing, you'll ruin your knees, get up—"

And she was reaching down and hauling, one hand under Magda's arm, and her grip was a great deal stronger than it looked and not steady at all.

"Ten years," she said, very low, for nobody else. "Ten years and not one person. Not one. And a pig-farmer kneels in the *mud* at a *ford*—"

She stopped. Swallowed it. Put the flat watchfulness back on like a hat, and it did not sit right any more, and she knew it did not.

"I don't know what to do with you," she said.

Then she offered her forearm, wrist to wrist, the woodland version of the way soldiers do it.

"Gardwen. My brother was taken by men in that armour. Ten years ago. He's the only thing I have left to look for, and I'm three days behind that column, and if your god has business with a dead man in dragon-scale then Hel and I want the same road for a while."

Neither of them, standing in the mud at the ford with their hands in a wolf, had the least idea that they had just described the same person.

CHAPTER 3 — A CITY WITH NO GROUND



THE CUSTOMS MAN AT THE WATER-GATE HAD A SYSTEM AND HE WAS PROUD OF IT, and it had worked all morning, and it was about to stop working.

Carts and cargo paid by the wheel. Foot traffic paid a tourney-week head-toll, or produced something that made it not worth his morning to argue, and he had already turned two people back and waved three nuns through without looking up. He had a tally-board under his arm. He had put a lot of himself into that board.

Magda did not wait to be got to. She went to him — straight up the outside of the line past the fishmonger and the family with the goat, which is wrong, and everyone in that queue knew it was wrong, and she could feel forty people deciding at once not to be involved.

He turned round with his mouth already open. Something practised. *Back in line, mother.*

She looked at him.

She has put her hand over the eyes of men who were shouting an hour before, and gone out afterwards and fed the pigs, because the pigs do not care. Whatever that does to a face, it has had fifty years to do it to hers. She let him have all of it.

“We’re going in.”

The mouth closed.

He looked at the staff, which is not a walking stick and has never once pretended to be. He looked at the wet grey animal watching him with the total, patient attention of something that has never in its life been told it is a good girl. He looked back at her face and did not find anything there that was negotiating.

She could see him reaching for the words — *toll, licence, by order of the Harbor Masters* — and she could see each one arrive, look at the situation, and decide against it.

“There’s a fee,” he said. It came out with no starch in it at all.

“There is.”

She let the pause go long enough for him to understand that she was not going to fill it.

He looked down at his board. “Two on foot,” he told it. “And a *dog*.” He wrote *dog*. Then he underlined *dog*, as though the underlining were a form of protest that history would one day recognise. “Muzzled inside the Merchant’s Quarter, that’s not me, that’s the Guild, and if it goes for anyone it’s your neck not mine—”

“Understood.”

“—and I never saw it.”

“You never did.”

He stepped aside. He did it small, so it wouldn’t look like stepping aside.

And as she went under the chain-boom he said it, not quite to her, in the flattened voice of a man reasserting something to himself: “Everyone’s mad this week. It’s the Tourney.” And then, because he could not help it, because the thing had been sitting in the top of his head since dawn:

“Third lot today gone through with something they won’t show me.”

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The noise arrived first. It comes up off the water and off the stone at the same time and hits you from underneath. Then the smell: salt, tar, fish, hot oil, wet rope, and under all of it the sweetish standing note of a city that sits in its own water and has made its peace with the arrangement.

Gardwen got six feet inside the gate and stopped dead with her back against a wall and her hand knotted in the wolf's fur, breathing like somebody who has just been put down somewhere with no trees in it.

"There's no *ground*," she said.

"Aye. It's all boats and barges and slipways here, lass."

She learned it the way woodland people learn things, which is badly for ten minutes and then all at once. Magda kept her on the inside with a hand flat to the wall, and after the third bridge she stopped looking at her feet, and after the fifth she was reading the water — which boat has right of way, which shout means *move*, which of the poled barges will take a passenger and which one is somebody's home. Ruhi hated every part of it and did it anyway, low and close, ears flat, a wet grey misery at heel.

The ferryman across the Lullwater charged them for the wolf and did not charge them for Gardwen, and would not explain why.

Bunting everywhere. Bad wine on trestles. Somebody's cousin selling favours in di Teufel colours off a tray, dragon-scale green, three for a copper, and doing extremely well out of it.

Away over the roofs a bell started up, and then another one, ragged and out of time with the first. Then they stopped. Nobody they passed seemed to know what they had been for.

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The Pearl is an island and it is the loudest quiet place in the city. Narrow, tall, swept, scrubbed, and lamplit at three in the afternoon because the alleys there never really get daylight. Music from some-

where above. Two women on a balcony watching the street the way farmers watch weather.

Halfway along a canal-side row there is a green door under a carved lintel — a sylph with her wings folded, worn nearly smooth by two hundred years of hands.

Magda knocked the way she had knocked twenty years ago, and the woman who opened it was a great deal older than that knock remembered.

“Magda.”

“Constantine.”

“You’re not dead.” Said with genuine delight, one professional to another.

“Not yet. It keeps being suggested.”

Constantine took in the rest of it in a single pass — the young woman standing much too straight, the staff, the wolf — and to her enormous credit the only thing that moved was one eyebrow, and only slightly.

“Beds,” she said. It was not a question. “It’s Tourney week, I’ve got the city and half the border in my lap and every room’s spoken for —” She stepped back and held the door wide. “—so you’ll have the top back room over the water, and it’s cold, and the shutter sticks, and I’ll bring a brazier up. Bring the dog. If it eats a client I’ll take it out of your purse.”

The hall smelled of beeswax and orange peel and, underneath, the honest fug of a house where a great many people sleep. A girl of about thirteen came past the foot of the stairs with an armful of linen twice her size, saw the wolf, stopped dead, and dropped the entire load.

“Ila,” Constantine said, without heat.

The girl was not listening. She was looking at Ruhi with her mouth open and her whole face lit up like a feast-day.

And on the landing above, leaning on the rail with her hair down and a cup of something in one hand, was a woman who did not appear to be in a hurry about anything, ever.

“Constantine,” she said down the stairwell, amused. “You’ve brought home a *wolf*.”

“I’ve brought home a *friend*, Emmeralda. The wolf is incidental.”

Emmeralda came down the stairs the way water comes down stairs, took Magda’s chin in two fingers and turned it, unhurried and professional and examining.

“Not one day. Not *one*. You were a hard old woman when I was a young one and you’re the same hard old woman now, and I’ve had two decades of people telling me *my* face is unnatural.”

“Mine’s a curse.”

“Mine’s an *asset*.”

Then, later, at the bottom of the stairs, with something under the brightness for just a moment: “You didn’t come for the Tourney.”

“No.”

“No.” She accepted it, and filed it, and did not push. Which was, in the event, the last decision anybody in that house made freely for some time.

CHAPTER 4 — NOT MY BUSINESS



THE KNOCK CAME AT THE HOUR WHEN A BROTHEL STOPS BEING A HOUSE AND STARTS being a business, and it was the kind of knock a young man gives a door when he is entirely certain of his welcome. Three, brisk.

Magda was three floors up with a brazier going and a shutter that stuck, and Gardwen was sitting with her back against the bed-frame cleaning mud off her boots with a knife, and Ruhi was asleep across the door, and none of them had any business with whoever that was.

Then a second voice in the hall. Young. Male. Well-bred. Border vowels.

And a name, clear enough through the floor to be certain of it: *Emmeralda*.

Magda stepped over the wolf and got the door shut without letting the latch speak, and went down as far as the turn above the second landing, where the overhang puts you in shadow and the hall lamp does not reach.

She has spent most of seventy years moving quietly around animals. She got where she was going and nobody marked it.

From up there she could see most of the hall. Constantine with her back turned. The young man facing her, hood back, dark clothes, road-

dust still on the hem — he had not changed since he rode in. Nothing in his hands. Talking quickly. Constantine nodding in the way she nods.

Then Emmeralda came in from the parlour door, changed since the afternoon — hair up, something green. She said something. The young man laughed.

Then she went up the near stair, the one that comes past the second landing, twelve feet from where Magda was standing.

He followed her.

They would pass below her in a few seconds. The shadow was good. It was not a wall. Staying put was about to become a contested thing, and there was no particular reason to be found on a stair in a house that was not hers.

She withdrew.

Not my business.

And it *wasn't*. That is the thing to hold on to, afterwards, and she did hold on to it, and it did not help at all. Constantine had run that house for thirty years. Emmeralda was not a girl. Hel had not walked her three hundred miles to mind a brothel door, and a woman who came in through the water-gate that morning without paying does not go and tell a nobleman that she does not care for his face.

She went back up. Gardwen did not ask, which was a thing Magda filed away about her. Ruhi resettled across the door and the house carried on being a house — the stringed instrument, someone laughing on the second landing, water working at the stone under the window.

She lay on the bed with her boots off and her staff under her hand where it always is, and looked at the ceiling, and after a while she went under.

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Somewhere below, an hour later, a young man who was not nearly as good at this as he believed attempted something he had never been

trusted with, and — against every expectation of his father's, and of his father's men, and very probably of his own — he got it right.

Then he tried to leave, and made a comprehensive disaster of it.

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There was no scream. That was the first thing, and it was worse than a scream.

There was a crash — something big going over, a table or a chest, and glass after it — and then a man's voice, high and completely undone, saying *no no no no* very fast. Then a door hitting a wall hard enough to shake the frame two floors up.

Running feet on the canal-side stair. A slip. A worse noise: a body hitting a landing full length, and something metal skittering away across boards.

More running. A shutter thrown.

And a splash in the canal below that was far too big to be a man getting neatly into a boat.

Magda came up out of sleep on animal reflex because Ruhi was already standing.

Then the house began shouting at itself all at once — Constantine bellowing with no words in it, a woman crying on the second floor, somebody hammering on a door.

Gardwen was on her feet with the boot-knife held low and reversed, looking at Magda, waiting to follow her lead.

The metal thing that skittered across the boards had not gone into the water.

And from the room the two of them had gone into: nothing at all.

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Going down three flights in the dark at speed at seventy is not a heroic act and Magda has never once pretended otherwise. Nothing dramatic

happened. She did not fall. She simply took the stairs at the pace a body takes them at the end of a long life, one hand hauling on the rail, with the lamp on the second landing gone out and the turns tight and every second of it audible to her as *not fast enough*.

She met Ila coming up. The girl hit her rather than stopped — two fistfuls of skirt, barefoot, white to the lips.

“She won’t *open* it—” hauling, trying to turn her round, back up the way she had come. “The door’s shut and she won’t open it and Constantine’s got the bar out and Emmeralda *won’t answer—*”

Gardwen went past both of them toward that door without breaking stride.

And Magda stood there for exactly as long as it took to notice that the canal-side stair kept going *down* — past the boot room, to the water door and the slipway — and that not one person in that house was going that way. Every soul under that roof was going up.

Down there in the dark it was quiet, and the water was still moving from whatever had gone into it.

She took the girl’s hands off her skirt.

She loaded as she went. Stone in the pouch, cord round the knuckles, staff cocked back along the forearm.

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The water door was unbarred and standing half open and swinging. Whoever came through it had left it that way.

Four stone steps going down into black water, green and slick below the third. A skiff moored to the ring at the bottom, riding oddly — the painter still tied but the boat shoved out and drifted back, rocking harder than the canal warranted.

The water directly off the slipway was still working. Not ripples. The deep, slow turnover of something that went in heavy and recently.

One lamp on the far bank, forty feet off, its light lying flat on the surface. Under that surface, nothing at all.

There was a shape on the second step down, right at the waterline, that was not stone. She got a hand on it and hauled it up: a cloak, heavy with canal, dark, good cloth, expensive, the hem still carrying road-dust under the wet. It had caught on the mooring ring. It had not come off a man who was being careful.

She dropped it on the step behind her, because it could wait.

Then she looked out across the water and found something to shoot at.

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Thirty feet out and moving left, upstream: the fast ugly chop of somebody swimming badly and in a hurry. A head. The pale smear of a face turning back toward the house. Then just the shoulders working.

He was making for the far ledge where the lamp was, where there was a set of iron rungs up the wall. Forty feet of open water between him and them, and he had covered maybe a third of it.

He had not seen her. She was a shape in a dark doorway and he was looking at the upper windows, where all the noise was.

Here is the whole of the reasoning, and it took about a second and a half.

She did not know his name. She did not know he was a baron's heir, or that the house would be turned upside down for him inside a day, or that a man with no colour in his face at all would spend three days walking that city with her description in his mouth. She did not know that killing him would put her between a border lord and everything he had spent a century building, or that it would cost a boatman his rest, or that in three days' time she would be standing in black water on a drowned island paying for it.

She knew that somebody had gone into a room in a house where she was a guest and done something to a woman in it that made a wolf refuse a doorway.

She knew he was thirty feet away and getting further.

And she knew she had a sling.

That is all the deliberation there was, and she has never once revised it.

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Backlit against the far lamp. Dark water. A moving target. She has been putting stones into rats and foxes and the occasional dog since before anybody now living in that house was born, and the range was nothing.

She set her feet on wet stone. The cord came round and the staff came over, and the stone went out flat across the water with that low buzzing note they make.

She did not hear it hit.

She *saw* it — the head snapped sideways, hard, wrong, the way a head does when it has stopped being steered from inside.

The working shoulders stopped working.

He went under without a sound. No thrashing, no cry, no arm coming up to grab at the world on the way past. The chop where he had been smoothed out into ordinary canal, and the wake he had been dragging caught up with the place he was not any more, and there was one hand above the surface for a moment, open, not grasping at anything.

And then that was gone too.

Forty feet away the lamp on the far bank went on being a lamp. The iron rungs he had been making for went on being empty.

The water closed and kept moving.

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She stood on the slipway a while longer with an empty sling in one hand, listening to it not stop moving, the way you stand at the side of a byre after you have done the thing you came to do.

Behind her, up in the house, a woman started screaming and this one did not stop. It was not Emmeralda's voice. It was older, and there were words in it, and Magda could not make out one of them.

Then Constantine, cutting across it, shouting for somebody to get a light. Get a light down here—

And feet on the stairs above her, coming down, toward the water door.

She picked the cloak up off the step and put it over her arm.

Not my business.

She had said that about two hours ago and it had been true when she said it and it was going to be a very long time before anything was true in that way again.

CHAPTER 5 — SHRIEKS OF THE SYLPH



CONSTANTINE HAD RUN THE SYLPH'S EMBRACE FOR THIRTY YEARS AND HAD BURIED two of her women and married off four more and had never once, in all that time, had to stand in a doorway of her own house and refuse to go into a room.

There were twenty-two people under her roof that night. Nineteen upstairs and three in the kitchen, and she could have told you every name and what each of them was owed and who was sending money home to whom.

She had been in the hall when he came. She had done the warm professional thing she does. She had thought, in passing, *this one is very bright tonight*, and had not made anything of it, because a young man with border money going up her stairs with his heart going is not a phenomenon, it is a Tuesday.

Now she was standing in a doorway with a bar in her hand and her people crowded in the passage behind her, and the smell that was coming out of that room was scorched hair and something sweetish underneath it, like fat gone over in a pan, and something else beneath *that* with no name she had for it, and the back of her throat kept closing on its own.

The wolf would not go through the door. That was the detail that finished her. The animal was braced in the doorway with its legs locked and its head low, snarling at a room with nothing in it.

Chalk on her floorboards. A worked figure, a big one, with corners on it, scuffed through at the foot where somebody standing inside it had gone backwards out in a hurry.

The shutter was off its latch and swinging and there was cold canal air coming in.

And Emmeralda was sitting up in the bed.

She was opened from the hollow of her throat to her hip. One long deliberate cut. Not a slash and not a stab — somebody had *drawn* it, slowly, with something barbed, and the edges of it were wrong, and it was still bleeding, and it was not being held closed by anything at all.

She had her head tilted slightly. She was looking at the door. She was smiling at Constantine.

“You needn’t crowd,” she said. Her own voice, perfectly level, pleasant. “It doesn’t hurt at all.”

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The druid girl had got there first and had been on the bed with both hands in it to the wrists, head down, saying something low and fast in no language anybody knew, and every hair on Constantine’s arms had gone up.

She had watched the flesh come together under the girl’s palms. She wants that on record. She *saw it close*.

And then she saw it open again from the inside, deliberately, the way a hand pulls a curtain back.

The girl came out into the passage afterwards with blood to both elbows that was not hers and her hands hanging at her sides, and stood against the wall, and said, “I closed it. Magda, I *closed it*. Both hands, everything I had, and it went in and it *took* — and then it opened again. On its own. Not tore. *Opened*. Like a mouth.”

Inside the room, quite clearly, in a warm and perfectly ordinary voice, Emmeralda was telling Constantine that he was fussing and that

she would like her green shawl, the one with the birds on it, because it was cold with the shutter open.

Constantine has been called by every name a woman in her trade gets called and has answered to most of them cheerfully. Nobody in that house had ever called her *he* in her life. She did not correct it. She stood in the doorway with the bar in her hand and she did not correct it, because the thing in the bed was using Emmeralda's mouth to be charming at her, and there did not seem to be a polite way to raise the matter.

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Then the old woman came up the stairs.

She had gone *down*, apparently, while everyone else in the house was going up, and she came back with a soaking cloak over her arm and the entirely settled expression of a woman who has been outside dealing with something.

She did not come straight in, either. She got as far as the doorway, and looked at the bed for about four seconds, and then went away again down the passage with the cloak, and Constantine — who had a great deal else to be looking at — registered it and did nothing about it.

She was gone perhaps a quarter of an hour. Constantine has since worked out roughly what she was doing in that quarter of an hour and has decided not to ask.

She went into the room. She sat on the bed when she was asked to. She let the thing pat the coverlet at her with a bloody hand.

And then, in the voice of a woman asking after a neighbour's roof, she asked it who the young gentleman had been, so that they would know how to greet him on his return.

It brightened at being consulted about hospitality.

"Santo," it said. "Just Santo — he didn't give me the rest, they never do, they think it's clever." A little conspiratorial lean, and the wound gaped with the movement. "He'll want the green room, I should think. He liked the birds on my shawl."

And then, thoughtfully, arranging the coverlet over the ruin of itself, house-proud:

“He said he’d come back for the others. Four more, he said, and then his father would *have* to see. He was quite emotional about it.” A small indulgent laugh. “Men and their fathers, Magda.”

Constantine got both hands flat on the doorframe and held herself up with them.

“*Santo*,” she said. “He said *Santo*.”

Because there is exactly one Santo who comes into this city in the week of the Lady’s Tourney with border vowels and a cloak that cost more than her front door, and he is the son and heir of Baron Hanzo di Teufel, who rode in through Caravan Square that same morning with twenty-odd Dragon Knights at his back and who was at that moment being toasted by half the men on the Governor’s council.

Twenty-two people under her roof.

A priest meant a report, and a report meant the Watch, and the Watch that week meant the Governor, and the Governor was drinking with that man’s father.

She got them into her counting room and put her back against the door and said, “What do we do?” — and understood, as she said it, that she was asking a pig-farmer from the north whom she had not seen in twenty years, and that she was going to do whatever the answer was.

CHAPTER 6 — FOUR STILL FULL



THE QUARTER OF AN HOUR THAT CONSTANTINE HAS DECIDED NOT TO ASK ABOUT WENT like this.

Magda had gone at the cloak once already, on the slipway, in the dark, with feet coming down the boot-room stair — and had not finished. Outer pockets first, because that is where a hurrying man puts things: a few coins, a folded scrap gone to pulp in the canal, a lump of resin or wax.

Then her hands had found weight. Something small and hard sewn in behind the lining at the breast, with no seam to it on the outside, needing a knife and a minute and a light.

She had none of the three, and there were people on the stair, so she had put it over her arm and gone up.

She got as far as the door of that room and stood in it for about four seconds, which was long enough.

Then she went back down the passage, because there is nothing an old woman can do for a thing like that and there was something an old woman could do about a wet coat.

Two doors along there is a linen closet with a lamp on a bracket.

She took the lamp, put the cloak on the floor, and opened it out flat.

Gardwen's knife would have been quicker and she was not going back into that room for it, so she used the thumb-edge of her own belt knife, and the stitching gave after a bit of arguing.

Two things came out of the lining.

The first was a **ring**. Heavy gold, a man's, big enough to want a knuckle, with a device cut into the face: a beast coiled round on itself, long, with its tail through its own jaws. Good work. Old work. Sewn into a cloak by somebody who did not want it on his hand that night.

The second was a twist of **oiled silk**, still dry inside. In it, a few long hairs bound at one end with fine copper wire, and a flake of something brown and hard that was not wax.

The hairs were not dark. In the lamplight they were dark red.

Emmeralda's are black to the root.

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Then she took the whole thing apart properly, unhurried now, with a lamp and the lining already open, seam by seam, the way you go through a carcass when you are not in a hurry and want to know what the animal died of.

The coins. Eleven of them, and wrong for Purewater — heavier, older, off a different mint. Border coin. He had not changed money since he arrived, which means he arrived recently and had not needed to.

A tailor's mark, stitched inside the collar where the wearer never looks. Not a Purewater house. A little tower with three windows, embroidered rather than stamped, which is a mark for somebody whose custom is worth the extra work.

The pulped paper, teased apart with the point of the knife and dried against the hot lamp glass. Most of it was grey mush. Two things survived: part of a line in a fine clerk's hand — *—ee days before the Lady's Tourney, at the hou—* — and the bottom half of a wax seal, broken, with the same beast on it as the ring.

And in the left cuff, folded over twice and stitched flat so that it would not rattle, a second twist of oiled silk.

Empty. Whatever had been in it had been used.

The first twist had three more like it wrapped in the same bundle.

All full. All hair.

None of it black.

*
**

She found Gardwen in the passage afterwards, out of the room now, with her back against the wall and her hands hanging. There was blood to both elbows and it was not hers.

“Where did you go?”

Magda leaned in and told her quietly. *I killed him in the water. Slingshot to his skull. Found his cloak too. He's got all sorts of weird shit, look...*

Gardwen went very still while she told it and did not interrupt once.

“Good,” she said about the killing. Flat, immediate, no hesitation in it at all.

Then, a moment later, quieter, as the rest of it arrived:

“—and bad. Because someone paid for that cloak.”

She took the twist of silk and turned it under the lamp and held it a long time, and her jaw worked.

“Hair and wire.” She shook her head, and there was something close to anger in it, and it was aimed at herself. “I know what a fever looks like in a badger. I know nine things you can do with willow. This is—”

She handed it back.

“I don't know what this is, Magda. I've never seen anything like it and I don't know anyone who has.”

Which is, in its way, the most useful thing anybody said in that house all night. She is not a woman who fills a silence with a guess.

When Gardwen of the Ash Vale tells you that she has no idea, you can build on it.

She looked at the bundles in Magda's palm and counted them, silently, her lips moving, and got to four, and stopped.

Because they had both heard that number about ten minutes earlier, out of the mouth of the thing in the green room, said warmly, as a piece of household gossip.

He said he'd come back for the others. Four more, he said.

It is one thing to be told a number by a demon that is enjoying itself. It is another to count it out in your hand.

"Four more," Gardwen said. "Four more *what*?"

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Neither of them had an answer and neither of them said the obvious thing, which is that somewhere out in that city there were four women going about their evening — going to bed, or not going to bed, or standing at a window complaining about the noise off the canal — who did not know that they had already been chosen, and picked out, and *shopped for*, and that a piece of each of them had come into Purewater sewn into a dead man's coat.

Above them, quite clearly, in a warm and perfectly ordinary voice, Emmeralda was asking Constantine whether the young gentleman had enjoyed himself, and when he might call again.

CHAPTER 7 — THE GIRL WHO DIVES FOR OARS



ILA WAS FROM THE SHOALS AND SHE HAD BEEN IN THE WATER BEFORE SHE COULD walk, which is the ordinary condition of tide-flat children and not, as Constantine kept insisting to people, some sort of accomplishment.

She dived for lost oars for a copper. She had once gone under the Lullwater bridge on a bet and come up the other side, and Constantine had taken the skin off her for it, and she had done it again the following week to establish the principle.

She was thirteen. She had been in that house for two years. Emmeralda had taught her to read the price list and then, when that turned out to be dull, had taught her to read properly, and had been extremely rude about her handwriting, and had given her a hair ribbon at midwinter that Ila kept in a tin.

That night two of the women were holding her by the arms in the kitchen so that she would not go upstairs and sit with Emmeralda, and she was fighting them silently, which is a great deal worse to watch than shouting.

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Constantine came down for her herself. She did not explain much on the way. She said there was a thing that had to be done in the

canal and that only Ila could do it, and that she could say no, and that Constantine would not think less of her, and that this was not Constantine's asking.

Ila was in the boat before anybody offered her a hand.

"I can go deeper than nine feet," she said immediately. "I can go under the *Lullwater*. Constantine, tell her—"

"I told her."

There was the wild woman with the wolf, soaked and grey and shivering in the bilge with a line still round her waist, and Ila felt a small unworthy stab of pity for a grown adult who evidently could not swim, and was too well brought up to say so.

And there was the old grandmother from the afternoon, sitting in the stern with a staff across her knees.

"What am I looking for?"

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The old woman did not soften it. That is the thing Ila has thought about most since.

"Look here love. The man who hurt Em is down there, dead and drowned with a caved in skull. You've got to go down and hook his body so I can drag him out and put him somewhere so we don't get in trouble."

Ila went completely still.

Not the fear. That came later. First there was just the arithmetic of it. *The man who hurt Em. Down there. Dead.*

"—caved in," she said.

"Aye."

"Who—" She stopped. She looked at the boathook lying in the bilge. She looked at the old woman. And she worked out, in about two seconds, that nobody in that boat was surprised, and that the woman

who had come in that morning with a wolf was the one giving the instructions.

“*You* did it.”

“Aye.”

And then the old woman said, “I know it’s hard but you’re all we’ve got to make it right,” and then, to the shivering wolf-woman, with something close to desperation in it: “Gardwen — fuck, help me explain. I’m no good at this.”

Which is when Gardwen got up out of the bilge water.

She was still shaking and her lips were blue and she did it anyway. She came forward on her knees so that she was down at Ila’s level and not looming over her, and she took the shawl the girl had already half shed and put it back round her shoulders, and her voice went quiet and completely steady, which it had not been all night.

“Ila. Look at me. When I was your age, men came to my house at night and killed my family. Every one of them. And I hid, because I was small and there was nothing else I could do, and I have spent ten years being the person who hid.”

Ila stared at her.

“Nobody’s asking you to hide. There’s a job, and you’re the only one in this boat who can do it, and it’s a *filthy* job. You’ll touch him. It’ll be cold and it’ll be dark and he’ll be heavier than you think and you will not like any part of it, and it will be over in a minute, and then Emmeralda’s house stays standing and everyone in it goes on living here.”

She put the end of the line into Ila’s hands.

“That’s the whole of it. You can say no. I’d not think less of you, and neither would she.”

Somewhere off toward the Lullwater a dog was barking. The canal moved under the boat.

Ila’s fingers closed on the line.

“Two tugs if I’ve got him,” she said. Her voice cracked in the middle of it and she carried on anyway. “Three if I need to come up.”

*
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She went in without a sound. No splash worth the name — she tipped backwards off the thwart and the water took her and closed over, and the line paid out smooth and steady and not in jerks, which is the difference between a swimmer and everybody else.

It went out a long way. It stopped.

Nothing for a count of ten. Nothing for a count of twenty.

Then two tugs. Firm. Deliberate. Then two more, and the line went heavy — properly heavy, dead-weight heavy, coming taut across the gunwale — and two pairs of hands got onto it and hauled.

She came up beside the boat with her arms wrapped round the line, gasping, hair plastered flat, not looking at anything at all except the sky.

“His face is *up*,” she said.

She said the right thing first. That is what the old woman told her afterwards and it turned out to be the thing she needed said.

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They took the wet shawl off her and dropped it in the bilge and put the old woman’s own cloak on her instead, which swamped her entirely and smelled of three weeks of road and pig and was dry. Then the old woman rubbed her arms hard, the way you bring a lamb round, brisk enough to hurt a bit.

“You went into black water on the word of an old woman you met this morning, and you found what you were sent for, and you came back up and you said the right thing first. That’s what you gave us. That’s the whole job. I’ve stood beside grown men in worse than this who did none of it.”

“I touched his—”

“Aye. You did. That’ll come back on you tonight and probably tomorrow and then less after that.” She pulled the cloak closed under Ila’s chin and held it there a moment. “It doesn’t mean anything’s wrong with you. It means you did a hard thing. There’s a difference, and nobody tells you, so I’m telling you.”

Ila made a sound and folded forward against her, and was allowed to, and cried properly for about a minute with her fists in the old woman’s shirt.

Then she stopped, because she was thirteen and mortified, and pulled back and scrubbed her face with the heel of her hand.

“Emmeralda’s still up there,” she said.

“She is.”

“Is she going to be all right?”

Behind them, Gardwen did not say anything at all.

CHAPTER 8 — A CITY THAT DREDGES IT-SELF



MAGDA'S FIRST PLAN WAS THE OBVIOUS ONE AND SHE PUT IT ON THE TABLE straight away, because it had the advantage of being what actually happens to rich fools in this city about twice a month. Put him somewhere on the approach. Leave the gold on him. Purewater thieves will kill a wealthy idiot for his rings quite happily, and everybody knows it, and the Watch will write it down without looking up.

Constantine did not hesitate. "Yes. God help me, yes. It's the only story that holds. A rich border boy comes to the Pearl with his father's gold on him and doesn't know the water, and he's found in the morning face-down off the Shoals with his purse cut and his rings gone." A glance at the ring on the table. "You've already done the hard part of that."

Then she stopped, and did the thing she is actually good at, which is finding the hole.

"But the body's in *my* canal. Behind *my* water door. And it went in heavy and it didn't come up. The outflow runs west past the Lullwater on the ebb — that's two hours off yet, and until then he's on the bottom in about nine feet of water more or less where you put him. After the ebb he could be anywhere, and 'anywhere' includes the grating at the Shoals, which they clear every morning with a *crowd* watching."

Which is how they came to be out on a canal in the dark with a boathook and a line and a thirteen-year-old, and how they came, after the girl had been taken back up the slipway wrapped in Magda's cloak, to be sitting in a skiff with a sack in the bottom of it and a decision still to make.

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There were two ways and Constantine laid them both out like a woman reading a ledger.

Leave the ring on him. Then whoever finds him strips him, and inside a day there is a Pearl thief trying to sell a di Teufel signet to a fence, and Crowbill's people hand that boy to the Dragon Knights themselves rather than have the trouble, and it is finished, and it was never here.

"But the moment that ring turns up, the Baron knows his son is dead. And a father who knows tears the city apart looking for the *why*."

Keep it. Then he is a drowned foreigner with his purse cut, and he stays nameless for two days, maybe three, while the Baron is still expecting him at supper.

"That's time. But there's no thief in the story, and 'nameless drowned man' is a story the Watch stops believing the moment somebody comes asking after a missing lord."

As for where — the Lullwater. Past the bridge on the north side there is a stretch of bad water and worse people, and men wash up there twice a month with their boots gone and nobody asks a single question. Two hours' poling. And two hours out on the canals with him in the bottom of the boat the whole way.

Magda shrugged.

"Keep the ring. Keep the clothes and the cloak. How about we do this — he's never found?"

Constantine looked at the sack for a while.

“Never found is harder than it sounds in a city that dredges itself,” she said. “You weight a man and drop him in a canal, and in six or seven days the gas brings him up with the weights still on him, and then it isn’t a drowning any more — it’s a *murder*, and the Watch works murders.”

She counted it off on her fingers, in the dark, in a boat.

“So it’s one of two. **Burn him** — and the only fires hot enough are the Forge Quarter’s, which means a guild furnace, which means a guildsman who saw you and wants paying every year for the rest of his life.” She shook her head slowly. “I’ve watched a man be bled that way. It doesn’t end.

“Or **the deep channel**, past the Shoals, where the harbour drops off into the sea. Opened so he doesn’t float. Weighted. On the ebb, so what’s left goes out and not back in. The ebb starts in an hour and a half and runs about four. That’s the window, and there isn’t another one before it’s light.

“That’s an hour’s poling to the harbour mouth in a boat with no light on it, past the Harbor Masters’ pontoon, and out into open water in a skiff that is not built for it. If a patrol stops us we are three people and a corpse and there’s no story that survives it.”

She stood up and took the pole.

A beat.

And Magda, sitting in the stern of a boat she did not own, listening to a madame with thirty years of running a house on the Pearl explain the tidal constraints on the disposal of a nobleman, smiled to herself.

Amateurs.

“Do you know anyone who keeps pigs?”

Constantine stared at her.

“Give me twenty minutes with a saw and I’ll have little old Santo here as a nice pile of butchered meat we just feed to the pigs. Then he’s shit and no one’s the wiser.”

It took her a moment to be sure Magda was serious, and then a moment longer to get past being sure.

"You're—" She stopped. Started again. "In my *house*."

"You've a boot room with a stone floor and a drain that goes straight into that canal. I saw it on the way down."

She opened her mouth and shut it, because that is exactly what she has.

She turned and looked at the water for a long time. When she spoke again her voice had gone somewhere flat and far away.

"There's a hog-yard on the edge of the Shoals. Man called Renko — he takes the kitchen waste off four houses on the Pearl, mine included. Two carts a week, before dawn, and one of them's tomorrow. He doesn't ask what's in the barrels. He never has. He's not a good man and he's not a talker, and he'd take coin to go on not being one."

She rubbed her face with both hands.

"It's *better*," she admitted, and hated it. "No boat. No Harbor Masters. No four-hour ebb window and no Lullwater. It's all *inside*, and it's done before the house wakes.

"But it's hours, Magda. It's hours of it, in my scullery, with twenty-two people asleep over your head and a demon in my green room asking for her shawl. And in the morning I have to stand in that room and take delivery of my own bread."

From the stern, quietly: "I'll help."

Constantine laughed. One, with no humour in it at all.

"Of course you will."

She put the pole in and brought the skiff round to the slipway.

"There's a saw and a cleaver in the scullery," she said. "And a bone-tub. Don't ask me why I know where they are."

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It is not fast and it is not hard. It is the same job it always is. You find the joint, you go through the joint, you do not fight the bone. The trick with a big carcass is patience and a sharp edge and Magda has had fifty years of both.

Gardwen held what needed holding and turned what needed turning and did not flinch once, which surprised Magda not at all.

The drain did its work. The canal took the rest.

They talked, because you do. Magda said something about having killed one of the enemy tonight, which was meant as encouragement, and Gardwen stopped with her hands on the table and looked down at the work.

“He’s the right age to be one of their sons. Not one of the men.” She turned a piece over without being asked. “Ten years ago he’d have been twelve. Sat at somebody’s table while it happened. Getting told the story after, probably, and being proud of it.” Her jaw set. “So no. Not one of the ones who came. But he grew up into exactly what they wanted him to grow into, and he did *that* to Emmeralda with four more women’s hair in his cloak, and I’d have put the stone through his head myself.”

She wiped her wrist across her forehead and left a mark there she did not know about.

“It’s a start. It’s not the one I came for.”

The saw went on. Somewhere over their heads a floorboard settled and both of them stopped, and it did not come again.

Then Gardwen said, not looking up: “Magda. That thing upstairs said *his father would have to see*. See what?”

“I’ve no idea. Nothing good.”

It took until the small hours. They scalded the slate and the floor and the drain with three kettles, and Gardwen put the saw and the cleaver back on their hooks exactly where they had been, which was somehow the worst part of the entire night.

Four barrels, with Constantine's own house-mark burned into the ends.

Renko's cart came at the fifth bell and Constantine walked it down herself, because it is not the sort of thing you send a boy with.

Above them, faintly, through three floors, a woman was laughing. Warm and easy and delighted.

Neither of them said anything about it.

CHAPTER 9 — TWENTY MINUTES



MARISSETTE RULES THE PEARL AND SHE DOES IT WITH LEDGERS, WHICH IS A THING people find disappointing when they finally get into the room and discover a woman in a plain grey wrap doing sums at four in the morning with her hair down and no jewellery on at all.

She had been up since the third bell, and she had not been up because she was worried. She had been up because her man on the bridge had come and told her something and then she had sat with it for an hour and a half, deciding whether to send men, and had decided to give them until dawn.

This is what he had told her. Noise at Constantine's, at about the third bell. A woman screaming, and then not screaming, which is worse. The water door open and a light on the slipway. The skiff out on the canal twice — once with three people in it, and once with four.

And that on the second trip one of the four had been Ila. That she had gone into the water. And that she had come out of it crying.

He had come and told her that last part because he knows Marisette likes Ila.

So when the black door opened at four in the morning and Constantine came in with a wet bundle and two strangers, Marisette had already done most of the work.

She poured coffee into three cups without asking whether anyone wanted it, and pushed them across, and sat back.

“Right. Before you start.”

She laid it out — the noise, the light, the two trips, the girl — flatly, in order, without any pleasure in it.

“You’ve got twenty minutes before I have to be someone else. Tell me what’s in my island.”

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The old woman was not, by her own admission, one for talking, and then talked anyway, and did it in about six sentences with no shape to them at all, which is a delivery Marisette has learned to trust more than eloquence.

One of Emmeralda’s clients had cut her open and put something in her. He had been swimming away. She had killed him with a sling. They had got him out of the water afterwards and turned him into pigment for disposal.

And then, in exactly the tone of a woman getting to the point at last:

It was Hanzo di Teufel’s son. He was planning on doing this to four more girls and he wanted to show his dad.

Marisette did not move at all while she talked.

When she stopped, Marisette reached out and turned one of the coffee cups a quarter-turn on its saucer, and that was the only thing that happened for about five seconds.

“Say the last part again.”

“Hanzo di Teufel’s son.”

“Santo.” Flatly, like checking a figure. “Twenty-two, black hair, very handsome, laughs before the end of the joke.”

“That’s him.”

“He came to my house three days ago asking after Asphodel and I turned him away because I didn’t like his hands.”

She is completely still when she says this and her voice does not change at all, which anybody who knows her would find alarming.

“I sent him to *Constantine’s*.”

Constantine said, “Marisette—”

“Don’t.” Not sharp. Just closed.

*
**

She went through the evidence the way she goes through stock. The ring she barely glanced at — turned it once, set it down. The letter she read twice. The coins she pushed aside.

Then she came to the four twists of oiled silk and opened the first one with her thumbnail, and the copper wire and the long dark red hairs came out into the lamplight.

And Marisette stopped.

She sat looking at it for a great deal longer than she had looked at anything else.

“Constantine. Who at your house has red hair?”

“Nobody.”

“No.” She laid the hairs flat on the desk and separated them with one fingernail, four or five strands, precisely, the way you lay out evidence. “Nobody at mine either.”

She looked up, and for the first time since they had come in she was not running the room.

“There are two women on this island with hair that colour, and I know them both, and neither of them works. One of them is a Watercrafter’s daughter.”

Her jaw tightened.

“The other is the High Priestess of the Lake Lady’s own niece.”

*
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The girl told her tale then, because the old woman nodded at her, and told it the way you would give a report — no shape to it, nothing arranged, which is somehow the worst possible way to hear it.

Nine of them. Eleven years old. She went back in the morning and counted them all and her brother was not there. He was seven. They had taken him alive and taken only him and burned the rest so nobody would count.

“That boy in the canal said his father would *have to see*. See what he’d made. That means his father makes things too. And his father has had my brother for ten years.”

Marisette sat back.

“A litter,” she said slowly. “Curtains sewn shut. Guards facing inward.”

“Aye.”

“He entered a champion for the Single Combat. Nobody has seen the man. It’s been the joke of the week — the Baron’s mystery swordsman. Not one soul in this city has laid eyes on him.”

She picked up the ring, finally, and turned it over.

“But a champion nobody has seen is not a champion. It’s a *thing being kept*. Men who are proud of a swordsman show him off. You parade him at the Siren’s Call, you let the odds move, you take money off the Guilds — that is the entire point of entering one.” She set it down. “Hanzo di Teufel has not let a living soul look at his. He has him behind a wall and a litter with the curtains stitched, and his guards face inward, and you don’t face inward to keep people out. You face inward to keep something *in*.”

“How old would your brother be now?”

“Seventeen,” Gardwen said.

It came out flat and immediate, the way a number does when you have counted it every year for ten years.

“He’d be seventeen. Santo was twenty-two.” Her hands had gone white on her knees. “It’s not him.”

“No,” Marisette agreed. “It isn’t.”

She let that sit exactly long enough.

“Seventeen is young for the Single Combat. It is not too young. I have seen younger die in it.”

The clock behind them went on being expensive.

“I’m not telling you it’s your brother, girl. I’ve no idea and neither have you and I’d not have you break yourself on a hope.” Said almost gently, which from her appeared to cost something. “I’m telling you that the thing in that estate is being hidden, and the boy who came out of it was carving women up to impress his father, and that his father is at this moment three streets from the Governor with a demon-worker’s blood in him and an entry in the Lady’s own Tourney.”

She stood.

“Which makes it my island’s business now, and I don’t have twenty minutes any more.”

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She looked at the old woman properly then, the way she had looked at the hair.

“Who are you?”

“Magda. I keep pigs.”

“Mm.” She did not smile. “You killed the Baron’s heir with a sling from a doorway in the dark, at what — thirty feet? — and then took him apart in a scullery and had him in barrels before the fifth bell.” A beat. “You keep pigs.”

“Aye. And other things.”

She accepted that. She wrote one line in the ledger and blotted it.

Then she gave them the only job in Purewater that nobody else could do, and she was honest about why.

“Every face I own is known on this island. My people can’t get within a street of that estate without it being reported to somebody by noon. You two walked through the water-gate yesterday morning. Nobody in this city knows your names.

“That is worth more than anything else you’ve brought me tonight.”

She sat back down and picked up her pen.

“So: sleep. Eat. And this afternoon I want to know what is behind that wall. Not a rescue. Not a fight. *Looking.*”

And then, without looking up:

“And when you find out whether that boy in the litter is seventeen, Gardwen — you come to me before you do anything about it. Not after.”

CHAPTER 10 — ONE BAG A DAY



YOU CAN SEE THE SHIP FROM THE SECOND BRIDGE, WHICH IS THE FIRST THING wrong with it, because a ship you can see from two districts away is not a ship anybody is hiding.

Above the roofs of the Forge Quarter there was the usual column of dark furnace smoke, and standing separate from it, lower down at the waterline, a long flat streak of white.

Steam. A hundred feet of it, coming off the water in a continuous sheet along a private pier, not stopping, with no fire under it.

The thing at that pier was a deep-water vessel, dragon-prowed, black-hulled, high out of the water and entirely out of scale with the canal traffic around it. Moored bow-in with her stern to the open channel and the Mouth beyond, which means she can leave at any hour without turning.

Where the hull met the water, the water was boiling. Gulls would not go near it. There was a dead-water slick round the stern with things floating in it belly-up.

Magda and Gardwen came at it along the working yards, which were working — coopers, a rope-walk, a chandler, men moving timber — and nobody stopped them, because two women walking through a working yard in the afternoon are furniture. Which is a fact about the world that Magda has spent seventy years being grateful for.

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She stood in the lee of the last cooperage for the better part of an hour and watched what a ship actually needs.

Not much went *on*. That was the first thing. No provisioning carts, no chandler's boy, no water butts — which is strange for a vessel that size at a pier, until you notice the covered gangway aft with the canvas laced down both sides, and understand that they are bringing everything aboard where nobody can see it, in their own hands, from their own boat.

Things came off, though.

Slops. Twice, a knight carried a covered pail down the ramp and emptied it into the dead water at the stern. Nobody collecting it. Nobody being paid to.

Laundry. A woman came at the second bell with a barrow and took a bagged load from the *pier head* — not from the deck; handed down to her by a knight who did not let her past the bollards — and went away again toward the rope-walk.

Ash and clinker, in barrows, from somewhere below decks, tipped on a spoil heap at the end of the yard. Far more of it than a galley fire makes.

And a cooper's boy delivered four new barrels to the pier head, left them, and was waved off. The knights carried them aboard themselves.

Nobody who was not a Dragon Knight had been past those bollards all afternoon.

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There was also, at the far end of the yard, a hog-man's cart with an old nag and two barrels and a lad who was not paying attention to anything, and who was making an enormous mess of backing the horse round.

Magda went over to help, because she knows all about hogs.

The horse was not impressed by her either. It laid its ears flat and swung its quarters and the offside wheel went into the spoil heap and the cart tipped far enough to put one of the barrels over on its side. The lid stayed on. Mostly.

The lad said a word she would have clipped him for.

Then they spent a couple of minutes getting the wheel out, and she got her shoulder under the barrel while he righted it, and by the end of it they were both filthy and he had stopped being embarrassed.

“She does that,” he said, glaring at the horse. “Every time. Every single time, right at the end.”

“She’s testing whether you’ve noticed her.”

“I’ve *noticed* her—”

“No, lad. She wants you to go to her head *before* she starts, not after.”

He considered this with the deep suspicion of a fifteen-year-old being told something obviously true.

His name was Pell. He did the Forge Quarter yards on alternate days for Renko out on the Shoals, which Magda kept her face entirely still about.

She had failed at the only thing she had set out to do, which was impress a boy with a horse, and had acquired a friend instead. This happens more often than anybody admits.

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He complained about the rope-walk, who had put nails in their waste last month. Then he jerked his chin down the pier at the steaming black hull.

“Not that lot, though. *They* don’t give us nothing.”

“Tight bunch, are they?”

“Tight? They’re *unnatural*, is what they are.”

And he counted it off, aggrieved, the way you complain about a bad customer, and handed her the entire shape of the thing without the least idea he was doing it.

Every yard on that side gave their waste to Renko. Cooperage, rope-walk, chandler; even the furnace lads gave up their bones. That is how it works. That lot tipped it in the water. In the *water*, right off the stern, good scraps, meat and all. Renko went down there himself on the first day and offered to take it for nothing — for *nothing* — and they walked him back up the pier by his elbows and told him not to come again.

And the ash. Barrows of it, off that ship, since the day she tied up. Show me the galley fire that makes that much clinker in a week.

“Only one that gets anything off them is the laundry woman. Yannick’s wife. Bag down at the bollards, coin in her hand, off you go. She’s not allowed past neither. She won’t talk about it, though. Went right off, she has. Which is a shame, ‘cause she’ll talk about anything.”

Magda thought about that for a moment.

“How big is the bag? Is there a lot of laundry?”

Pell stopped, and actually thought about it, which he clearly never had.

“Not big. One bag. She carries it on the barrow but she could carry it on her hip if she wanted — I’ve seen her lift it one-handed off the bollard.”

He frowned.

“Every day, though. That’s the thing, now you say it. Rope-walk’s forty men and they send out twice a week. That ship sends out *every day* and it’s one bag.”

He clicked at the horse.

“And it’s all the same, she said once before she went quiet on it. Not shirts and hose and what-have-you like a normal house. All the one thing. Sheets, I suppose. Bedding.”

He got the nag moving, and said the rest over his shoulder, cheerfully, with no idea at all what he was handing her:

“She had a right go at Renko about it in the tavern, first week. Said she’d take their coin but she’d not take it long, and if they wanted that much *boiling* every day they could get a woman with a stronger stomach.”

He raised a hand. “Alternate days, missus! Tell Renko I said you know your horses!”

And the cart lurched away up the yard, and the nag did the thing with her quarters again exactly as predicted.

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Magda went back to counting.

Eight. That was all of them. Two at the pier head, two at the top of the ramp, three working on deck — one of whom did nothing at all but walk the same twenty feet over and over and look at the shore — and one who came up out of the aft hatch with a barrow of clinker, went down the ramp, tipped it, and went back.

Eight men. In scale, all of them, on a hot afternoon, aboard a moored ship. Nobody in shirtsleeves. Nobody idle. Nobody talking.

No banner at the masthead. For a nobleman in residence there would be colours flying; every other hull in that harbour with anybody aboard had something up. That mast was bare.

No Baron. Nothing in anything but scale and livery. No servants, no clerk, no valet, nothing that looked like a household. The good clothes and the gold were somewhere else — north-west round the point, where the boat went.

And the shutters amidships had not opened once all afternoon. It was a warm bright day and every port on every hull on that water was open to air the ship out, and those were closed, and — now that she looked at them properly — they were closed from the *outside*. There was a bar across.

Gardwen had gone very quiet beside her.

“Magda,” she said. “Sheets. Every day. Boiled.”

CHAPTER 11 — BOILED BLOOD



ANN YANNICK HAD WASHED FOR THIS QUARTER FOR TWENTY-TWO YEARS AND IN THAT time she had done a house with a consumptive in it, a birth-bed that went wrong, and a man who lost a hand at the rope-walk, and she could tell you the difference between all three by the shape of the stain.

That is not a boast. It is simply what the work is. You get a shape to it — where it came from, how it lay, whether he thrashed. Blood is a language and she has been reading it since she was nineteen.

For four mornings she had been washing something she could not read at all, and her husband did not want to hear about it, and there was nobody else.

She was up to her forearms when the shadow fell across the door.

“If it’s for the rope-walk you’re a day early.”

Behind her, on the end copper — the one furthest from the door, on its own — there was a load going that was not like the others, with the lid half over it. The water in it had been changed recently; there was a grey slick round the rim where it had been tipped out and the drain channel by her feet ran the wrong colour and had not been sluiced. And there was a stack of clean folded sheets by the door with a cloth over them, and the cloth did not quite cover the corner of the top one, and that corner had a stain in it that had been boiled at and had not

come out. It had gone the brown that blood goes when you cook it into cloth.

The old woman in the doorway was looking at it.

Then she came in out of the sun, took the bench by the door where the draught is, and sat down the way a woman of seventy sits down — all at once, with a noise.

And then she did not say anything.

She looked at her boots. She rubbed her knee. She observed, once, to nobody in particular, that the steam was pleasant on the joints.

The young one who had come with her stayed outside in the yard with her back to the wall, which Ann noted and did not comment on.

Copper. Lift. Turn. Copper.

Four days of it, with a husband who says take the coin.

It took a long while. The old woman got most of the way through not asking.

Then Ann lifted a load, dropped it, wiped her forehead with the back of her wrist, and said it to the copper rather than to her:

“Do you know what boiled blood smells like?”

The old woman said nothing.

“Course you do. You’ve a face like you’ve buried people.”

And out it came.

“Four days I’ve had that. Every morning. One bag, and it’s all sheets, and every one of them’s the same.

“It’s not a wound. This is the *same shape* every day. Same place on the sheet. Same size. Like it’s been let out of him careful, in the same spot, and mopped, and put back.

“And there’s something else in it that doesn’t come out. Not blood. Blood boils out with lye and time. That doesn’t. It goes *grey*, and it smells like the forge, and my hands were numb to the elbow the first day and I’ve worn gloves since.”

She put the paddle down.

“They pay double. My man says take it. And I lie there at night thinking — whoever’s in that ship, he’s still bleeding tomorrow. Four days. Somebody’s keeping him alive to do it again.”

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And then the old woman made a joke about it.

She meant well. Ann is prepared to say that now, at a distance. She arranged her face into something sympathetic first, which was worse than not trying — her face does not know how to be that, and what it produced was closer to indigestion — and then she said something about honest work, and how most folk pay double to keep blood *off* their sheets, not on.

It is the sort of thing that is funny in a byre at four in the morning with people who have been up all night with a bad calving.

It is not funny in a wash-house.

It landed in the steam and died there.

Ann Yannick’s face closed like a door. She picked the paddle back up and the rhythm changed — shorter, harder, the movements of a woman who has remembered she is working.

“You’re not from the yards,” she said.

Not hostile. Worse: careful.

“You came in with a young one who’s stood outside my door instead of coming in, and you sat down and let me talk, and you’ve asked me nothing, which is how the Watch does it and how Crowbill’s do it and how a certain sort of woman from the Pearl does it. And now you’ve made a joke about blood.

“So I’ll ask, since you won’t. Who are you, and why do you care what’s in my coppers?”

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Here is what saved it, and Ann has thought about this since.

The old woman did not try the joke again, and she did not try charm, which she has none of. She told the truth, flatly, and let Ann decide about it.

North. Cold winds and sharp ice. *I joke about blood because I've seen and cleaned up my fair share. And: the men on that boat are up to some evil shit that might need stopping. Sounds like you're thinking the same way.*

Ann looked at her for a long moment through the steam. She has been lied to by better liars than that, and she did not find what she was checking for.

"North," she said. "Aye. I thought there was something in the vowels."

She worked for a bit.

"Evil shit that might need stopping," she repeated, and something that was not quite a laugh came out of her. "My man says I'm being a woman about it."

She lifted a sheet out, wrung it, dropped it into the rinse.

"Three things, then. And I'll deny every one of them if you ever say I said it.

"One. It's not a sick lad. Sick men sweat, and they piss the bed, and they stink of the sickness. There's none of that. Whoever's in that bed isn't ill and isn't dying and isn't getting better. He's being *kept*.

"Two. Second morning, the bag came down heavier and there was a shirt in it. Not linen — a fighting man's under-shirt, quilted, for wearing under scale." She paused. "The arming-points were cut. Not untied. *Cut*, all of them, front and back, the way you do when you're getting something off a man who isn't helping you.

"Three."

She stopped paddling.

“The knight who hands the bag down. Big fellow, white eyebrows, no colour in him at all — he’s the one that walked Renko off the pier. Yesterday he asks me, all friendly, whether I ever wash for the houses on the Pearl. Whether I know anyone that does.”

She looked straight at her.

“I said no. But he wasn’t asking about laundry, was he.”

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The old woman asked her about Marisette then, which Ann thought was a strange turn until she understood that it was not.

“Everyone knows Marisette. She’s not on this side of the water but she doesn’t need to be.” She turned a load. “What do I think of her. She’s not *kind*. Don’t let anyone tell you she is. She’ll take a girl’s whole life apart to keep her house standing and she’ll do the sums out loud while she does it.

“But she’s straight. That’s rarer. She says a price and it’s the price. And when Ganny Corliss’s daughter got herself in trouble with a Watercrafter’s son two winters back — a Forge Quarter girl, mind, nothing of hers, no reason at all — Marisette had the Guild sat down and settled inside a fortnight, and the girl kept the child and the money, and the boy’s father still can’t say her name without going purple.”

She wrung out the sheet.

“So. She’s a hard woman who looks after women. There’s worse to be.”

Then her hands went still in the water, and she arrived at it.

“You *are* off the Pearl.”

She looked at the door, at the young one standing in the yard.

“And that white-haired bastard was asking me yesterday about women who do laundry for the Pearl houses. He wasn’t hunting a washerwoman. He’s hunting something that went *from* here *to* there. Or from there to here.”

She pulled her hands out of the copper and dried them on her apron, and she was not calm any more.

“What did you people *do*?”

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The old woman told her that too, more or less. And then she said the thing that made up Ann Yannick’s mind for her, and she said it standing in a doorway with the steam going past her, in the flat voice of a woman reading a list:

“I got here yesterday — my loyalty’s to Hel and that girl standing outside and no one else.

“These men are stone killers. The albino worse than most... so be careful what you tell that one.

“At some point, you have to choose sides.”

A beat.

“Which part of the boy are they bleeding?”

That is the whole of it. Four sentences, no persuasion in any of them, and the last one asked as though the answer were already agreed and only the detail outstanding.

Ann has thought since about why that worked when the joke did not, and she has concluded that it is because the old woman did not once ask her to be brave. She told her what the men were, and warned her about the worst of them, and then named the thing plainly — *at some point, you have to choose sides* — and left it sitting there, and went straight on to the practical question as if Ann had already chosen.

Which, of course, she had. Four mornings ago. She simply had not said it to anybody.

Ann took a clean sheet off the folded stack and shook it out flat across the bench between them and put her hand down on it.

“Sheet goes on the bed this way — hem to the head, you can tell from the wear where a man’s heels go. So.” She laid her palm high on

it, a little left of the middle. “It’s *here*. Every morning, four days. About the size of my two hands together.”

She spread her fingers.

“Upper body. Left side. Chest, or just under the arm — high enough that if he was on his back it ran sideways, because the edge of it’s always feathered toward the outside. Same spot, same size, and it’s *sharp*-edged, not spread. That’s not a wound that’s healing and breaking open. A healing wound weeps different every day, wider then narrower, and the shape wanders. This doesn’t wander.

“Somebody opens the same place, the same way, every morning. And then somebody else changes the bed.

“And the grey. That’s not in the blood. It’s *round* it — you get the red out and the grey stays behind in a ring, like a scorch. That’s what numbs your hands.”

She folded the sheet and squared it off on the stack and stood there with both hands on it.

“You said choose sides.”

She went to the end copper and lifted the lid off and started fishing the load out into a basket with the paddle, and slapped it down wet.

“They’re due at the sixth bell for that. They’ll get it. I’ll smile at the white-haired bastard and take his coin.”

She looked up.

“But you tell Marisette that Ann Yannick washes for that ship every morning, and she’ll go on doing it, and she’ll go on *looking*. And if that boy’s still bleeding on the day of the Tourney, I want somebody to have done something about it.”

The old woman put a hand on her shoulder on the way out. Not a pat. She took the weight of it, once, the way you grip a man’s arm before he goes over a wall.

Ann reached up and put her wet hand over it and held it there a moment, and neither of them said anything, because there was nothing that would have improved it.

CHAPTER 12 — A THING BEING KEPT



HESPER HAD SPENT THIRTY HOURS IN A GREEN ROOM ON THE PEARL WITH A DEMON that would not stop talking to him, and he had come away with a notebook full of very small handwriting and the settled conviction that boredom is the most underrated interrogation technique in the profession.

He is an unremarkable man. That is deliberate and it has taken work. Plain dark coat, physician's bag, a voice that does nothing at all, and thirty years of being the person nobody in a room afterwards can describe.

He was in the corner of Marisette's counting room when the two of them came back from the Forge Quarter at dusk, and he had been sitting there with a cup of something going cold since before they arrived, and neither of them had noticed him on the way in, which he permitted himself a small private pleasure about.

Marisette listened to the whole of the recon without interrupting once. Eight men. No banner. No Baron. The boat from the north-west. The barred shutter. The barrows of clinker. One bag a day. The same place on the sheet. The cut arming-points. And the laundress's name and the laundress's message.

At the end she said, "Eight." And then, differently, "*Eight.*"

And then: "Ann Yannick will not lose that work, and she will not be alone in that wash-house again after tomorrow. I'll see to it."

Hesper put his cup down.

“Your friend asked after the courtesan. She’s alive. She’ll stay alive. It’s got no interest in killing her — quite the reverse, it likes the house and it likes being fussed over and it has been extremely helpful all afternoon, which is the part I want to talk to you about.

“But I’d rather start with what you just said. Because a wound in the same place, opened every morning, with a grey scorch round it that numbs the hands—”

He stopped.

“How long has that ship been at that pier?”

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This is the part that Hesper has taught for years and never once had to use.

The Baron rode in through Caravan Square yesterday at midday. Marisette had it from three people within the hour.

But the ship came before him. She came by sea, round the Mouth, and tied up at that pier five days ago — Marisette knows because the Harbor Masters made a noise about the berth and were made to stop making a noise about it.

Five days. And the laundress has been washing that bed for four.

“Then it started the day *after* the ship tied up, and the Baron was still three days up the road when it did.”

He sat forward.

“Do you see what that means? Nobody started anything here. That is a *routine*. That is a thing that has been done to somebody every morning for however long, in whatever house it was done in before, and they carried on doing it at sea, and they carried on doing it here.”

He picked the cup up, found it cold, put it down again.

“And they brought him by *water*. Twenty-odd knights ride three days up the road in the open, and the thing in the litter goes round

by sea in a hull that steams. You don't do that for a champion. You do that because a road has villages on it, and villages have people in them, and whatever is in that cabin cannot be taken past people for three days."

Marisette said quietly: "Hesper."

"I know."

"Tell them what it said."

He was silent for a moment.

"The thing in Emmeralda spent the afternoon complaining. It's bored, it's fond of the girl's memories, and it will talk about anything to anyone who'll sit with it. And what it complained about, at some length, was that it had been promised something better than a courtesan.

"It said its master's father keeps a *proper* one. And that his is 'the old kind, the kind that remembers being a person.'"

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The old woman grunted at that. *Like a ghost? Like a dead knight?*

And then she told him about her goddess.

Eleven nights. A woman with a wolf. A burning house. A knight in dragon-scale who is dead and has not been told.

And the instruction.

Lay the dragon warrior to rest.

Hesper did not say anything for a long time. When he did, the unremarkableness had gone out of his voice, which is a thing that happens to him perhaps twice a decade.

"Say the last part again."

"Lay the dragon warrior to rest."

"*Rest*," he repeated. "Not destroy. Not banish. **Rest**." He put both hands flat on his knees. "Madam, you don't lay a demon to rest. There's

nothing in a demon to rest. You bind it or you break it and either way you may as well be arguing with a fire.

“You lay a *dead man* to rest.”

He stood up and took two steps and stopped, because it is a small room.

“The old kind. The kind that remembers being a person.” He turned round. “That is a **shade**. A person who died and did not go where the dead go — kept, and bound, and put somewhere. And you cannot keep a shade in a jar or a stone for long; it wears through. You keep it in a *living body*, because a living body renews itself, and the wearing-through goes into the flesh instead of the vessel.

“Which is why somebody opens the same place on that boy’s chest every single morning. It is not torture and it is not a ritual scar. It’s *maintenance*. You bleed the host to keep the seat clean. The grey your laundress can’t boil out is what comes off the seam — that’s the shade’s wear coming out of him with the blood, and it’s numbing her hands through a copper of lye.”

The druid girl had not moved at all.

“How long,” she said, “can they keep a person like that?”

“Years,” said Hesper. “If they start young enough that the body grows around it.”

She sat down.

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He watched the old woman go over to her afterwards and put a hand on the back of her neck, and it was not a gentle gesture, and it was exactly the right one.

“Seventeen,” the girl said. “*If they start young enough.*”

“Aye.”

“He was seven, Magda. I’ve spent ten years hoping he was alive.” Her voice was very steady and very small. “I never once thought about what for.”

“I’m all right.”

“You’re not.”

“No.” A pause. “But I’ll do.”

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And then the old woman asked about the bells.

Hesper had not thought about the bells. He is prepared to admit that. He had been in a room with a demon for thirty hours and had not once considered that anything was happening outside it.

Marisette set her cup down.

“Yes. Yesterday, just after midday. Everyone assumed it was for the Baron’s entry, because it started while the column was in Caravan Square and this city will assume anything.”

“It wasn’t?”

“It was the Lady’s temple on Temple Isle. And that wasn’t a welcome peal, it was ragged and out of order and it came from the water-tower, not the campanile.” Her mouth thinned. “That’s the *fouling* alarm. They ring it when something goes wrong with the sacred channel — a dead beast in the intake, a spill, a body. It’s been rung four times in my life.”

Hesper said quietly: “And they stopped it inside a quarter of an hour.”

“They did. Which they don’t do unless somebody senior tells them to.”

She looked at the old woman.

“The High Priestess Nerissa rang the alarm on the day Hanzo di Teufel entered this city, and then somebody had it silenced before the third peal, and nobody has said a word about it since.”

She picked the pen up and put it down again.

“And her niece has red hair.”

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The old woman's face went hard at that, and she squared off at Marisette and said the obvious thing, which is that there are only eight of them on that boat and with enough men you could simply go and take him. She was honest that it was not the smartest way. She said it was her way.

Marisette did not flinch and she did not laugh.

“Eight is eight. I can put twenty men at that pier before the sixth bell tomorrow. Crowbill can put forty, and he'd do it for what's in your purse.

“And then I have twenty men against eight Dragon Knights in scale, on a deck, at night, and I lose eleven of them and it's still even money. And by dawn every one of them has a name and a mother on this island, and Hanzo di Teufel — who is at this moment eating supper with the Governor's brother — knows to the hour who came for his ship.”

She spread her hands.

“It's not that it's stupid, Magda. It's that it's *last*. You only get to do it once, and after you've done it there is nothing else you can do.”

Which was correct, and Hesper let it stand, and then said the part that actually frightened him.

“There's a worse problem. You'd be stealing a lit lamp.”

He leaned forward.

“Whatever is seated in that boy is held there by something, and it is not the ship and it is not those eight men. Take the body out and you have not freed anyone — you have carried a bound shade into the middle of the Pearl with its keepers coming after it, and the first thing that happens when the maintenance stops is that the wearing-through goes somewhere else.”

He looked at Marisette, then at the old woman.

“You cannot rescue him until you know what the anchor is. Otherwise you’re not rescuing a boy. You’re moving a problem into a house full of women.”

CHAPTER 13 — FOUR MINUTES AFTER NOON



NERISSA HAS SERVED IN THAT TEMPLE SINCE SHE WAS NINETEEN AND IN forty-two years the channel has never once done what it did at four minutes after noon on the day Hanzo di Teufel entered the city.

Not fouled. She has had fouled. Fouled is a dead ox in the intake and a week of prayers and a great deal of tedious correspondence with the Harbor Masters.

This went *thin*.

The Lady's presence in her own water went thin, the way a voice goes thin at a distance, in the space of about ten heartbeats, and Nerissa was standing in the tank with her sleeves rolled when it happened and she felt it go out from underneath her hands.

So she rang the tower.

And by the third peal there was a boy from the Governor's household at her gate with a written instruction to cease, on the grounds that the city was welcoming a distinguished guest and the bells were causing alarm during a formal entry.

Written and sealed by Prince Emeric. Who is twenty-four years old, and well-meaning, and who has been told by three separate men

on his council this fortnight that his uncle would like the Tourney to go smoothly.

And she stopped.

She has been furious about that for a day and a half, and the fury has nowhere to go, because she was also right to stop. She is the High Priestess of a temple paid for by that city's Guilds and she had *nothing* — a thin feeling in the water and no cause she could name in front of a magistrate. If she had rung on she would have been removed by Thursday and replaced by somebody who would not ring at all.

She had not slept since.

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She was sitting on the step of the great tank at midnight with her feet in the water and her sleeves pushed up, doing nothing at all, when Lilura came down the colonnade at a pace that was not quite running with a note in her hand and a wolf at the gate.

Marisette does not send people to her. Ever. That was the first thing.

The second thing was that the wolf sat down in the middle of the gateway and looked at one of the Swords until he moved his feet, and that half the watch had made a sign at it, which is the oldest shape their faith has and Marisette knew exactly what she was doing when she sent it.

They came in through the colonnade past the tank where the channel runs through the temple itself, and the sound in that room is enormous, water on stone, everywhere, no other noise at all.

Nerissa did not get up.

"Leave the wolf. It can drink. Nothing in this water will mind."

And then, with no ceremony left in her whatsoever:

"Marisette does not send people to me. Ever. So say the worst of it first and we'll work backwards."

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The old woman said the worst of it first.

That she had killed Hanzo's son after he bound a demon into one of the girls at the Sylph's Embrace, and then fed his body to pigs. That working backwards from there, they thought he had been planning to do the same thing to Nerissa's niece. And that they thought the Dragon Knights had taken the young one's brother ten years ago and were hosting a shade in him so that he could fight in the Tourney in a few days.

That's about all of it.

She said it with blue eyes gleaming and a perfectly sweet smile.

Nerissa has spent thirty years listening to people lie in that room. She read her all the way through and did not find a single untruth anywhere in her, which was in some ways more alarming.

She did not move for a while. Her feet stayed in the water.

"You smiled," she said at last, "when you said *pigs*."

"Aye."

"Mm." She took her feet out of the tank and dried them on the hem of her robe like a farmer's wife, and got up. "Good. I'd not trust a person who could say that flatly."

Then she told them hers, and they were even.

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They put it on the low table by the lamp and took it apart for her the way you show somebody a bad joint of meat. The cloak. The tailor's tower. The ring. The letter. The eleven coins.

And then the oiled silk. Five of them. Four still full.

Nerissa picked up the first twist. She did not open it. She held it, and her thumb moved once across the silk.

"So he came into this city carrying five women in his coat," she said. "And he spent one of them on a girl at Constantine's, and he had four left."

She opened it then, and let the hair out into the lamplight, and looked at it for a long moment.

Then she asked the question that nobody else in four days had thought to ask, and she asked it in a voice that had gone completely level.

“Beneath the wire. Is there a knot in it, or is it cut clean at both ends?”

The old woman turned it. The wire was at one end. The other end of the hank was blunt and square, all the strands the same length.

“Cut clean.”

“Then it was taken with shears, off a head, by somebody standing behind her.”

She laid it down very carefully.

“It was not gathered off a comb or a pillow. Somebody got close enough to my sister’s daughter to put shears in her hair, and she did not scream, and she has not told me.”

She looked up.

“Her name is Sana. She’s nineteen. She has been at the temple school for six weeks and I have not seen her in three.”

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There is one more thing about that night that Nerissa has not told anybody and does not intend to.

Her sister has had two letters from Sana in six weeks. The first came at the end of the fourth week and it was ordinary. The second came eight days ago and it was three lines, and it was *fine*, and her sister brought it to her and said “she’s settling,” and Nerissa said “good.”

Three lines.

In a hand she would know anywhere. From a girl who once wrote her eleven pages about a heron.

She had read it and she had handed it back and she had said *good*, and then she had gone and done something else, and the day after that the water went thin and she rang a bell and a boy brought her a letter telling her to stop.

She stood up and started unpinning her sleeves.

“Bring the wolf,” she said.

And she went down the colonnade toward the water-stair at a pace that a woman of sixty ought not to have been able to manage, and nobody who was there said anything about it, because everybody there had worked out what was driving her and none of them were fools.

CHAPTER 14 — THE DROWNED STREET



GARDWEN HAD BEEN RUN AS A PAIR OF HANDS FOR TWO DAYS AND SHE WAS starting to notice it. She had closed a wound with her palms and healed a leg and hauled on a line and held a girl's shoulders in a boat, and at no point had anybody — including, if she is honest, herself — remembered that she is a priest with nine spells and a goddess who answers.

It came back to her at Corbie's, standing on a water-stair at one in the morning looking at four hundred yards of black channel with a dull red light moving on the far side of it.

The mistress of the school had been crying. She had opened the door and seen Nerissa and her face had done something terrible.

"We sent to you at *dusk*," she said. "We sent a boat at dusk, Mother — didn't it come?"

Nerissa went very still on the step. "No. Nothing came."

"Sana's gone. Since yesterday morning. We've had every girl out looking and we've dragged the channel and I sent Bettan to the temple *myself*—"

And out across the water, on an island where there is nothing at all, a light that was too low and the wrong colour was moving in a straight line, and stopping, and after a while moving again.

“Magda,” Gardwen said. “I can find out what’s on that island from here, if the Lady’s willing to lend me the eyes for it. But it’ll cost me, and whatever’s over there might feel it done.”

“We need to know where the girl is. Do it.”

**

She went down on one knee at the water’s edge and put both hands flat in the channel and said something under her breath that had the shape of a name in it.

And she felt the room open — the way the air goes when a door opens somewhere else in a house.

Then it closed. Nothing came.

She sat back on her heels, breathing like she had run there.

“Too far. It’s not the distance, it’s — the water’s all *hers* here, and I’m not hers, and I was asking a favour in someone else’s house. I got about halfway across and it went out like a candle in a draught.”

One magic point gone and nothing to show for it.

Nerissa had been watching her the whole time with an expression Gardwen could not read at all.

“You reached,” she said. It was not a question. “From the bank. Across running water that isn’t yours, at a rank you shouldn’t manage.”

“I didn’t reach far enough.”

“No.” Nerissa was already unpinning her other sleeve. “You reached *at all*. Girl — you were asking a favour in someone else’s house because you were standing on the doorstep shouting.”

She stepped down into the channel until she was shin-deep and held out her hand.

“So come inside and ask properly. Take my hand and do it again, and this time the Lady will hear where it came from.”

Across the water, the dull red light stopped moving.

Then it went out.

*
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There was one more thing, and it was the old woman who said it, and Gardwen has thought about it since.

Could she use a passion to augment it?

A woman who has spent ten years looking for a taken child, being asked to find a taken girl. It is not a trick. It is simply that the thing you love hardest is a lever and nobody had thought to put it under this.

She took Nerissa's hand and went into the channel up to her knees, and the second time was not like the first.

Her fingers locked on Nerissa's hard enough to hurt and her breath went out of her all at once, and the priestess stood in the water and took it without moving, the way you hold a rope.

Then Gardwen started talking, fast and flat, describing as she went.

"There's — the whole island's *humming*. Underneath. Not evil, just old, there's a great deal of something old down under the weed and it doesn't care about us at all. Above that. On the stone. There's a *working*."

"Say what you see," Nerissa said quietly.

"Same flavour as the chalk on her floor. Same hand. It's not finished — it's *laid out*, like a table before dinner. It's cold. It's been cold a while. Whoever set it hasn't come back to it in a day or more."

"Living things."

"Two moving." Her head turned, slowly, tracking. "Both of them wrong. Not demons — *men*, but wrong, the way milk's wrong. They're low down and they're together and they've stopped, they've gone still since the light went out—"

She stopped. Her whole face changed.

"There's a third. Not moving. Not wrong." Her voice cracked. "She's *small* in it, Magda, she's gone right down small the way you do when you're hiding — and she's above the other two, up high, in the stone."

Nerissa's grip tightened. "Is she alive?"

"She's *frightened*," Gardwen said. "You can't be frightened if you're not alive."

Then she opened her eyes and looked straight across four hundred yards of black water at an island where nothing showed at all.

"She's been there since yesterday morning and they haven't found her yet."

*
**

They gave Gardwen the plan and she took it, because it was the one thing that night she was actually trained for. She crouched and drew it in the mud of the bank with her finger.

Their boat first. They came out here somehow and it will be on the north side with them, and if they are spooked they run for it, and then we have nothing and they have a day's start. Take it or hole it before anything else happens. That is the whole game — do that and they are on a two-hundred-yard rock with us.

Then Sana. She has been in that stone since yesterday morning with no water and she is hiding from anything that moves, and if a Sword in armour comes round a corner at her she will bolt into the weed in the dark and be lost for good. So it is me and Ruhi who go up, and it is me who calls to her, because I am the only one here who is not wearing anything.

Then the two men. Not before. Once the boat is gone and the girl is out they have nowhere to be and nothing to bargain with, and we take them at our leisure, from three sides, with a priestess and two Swords.

"Alive if they'll have it. Because whoever laid that working knows what the anchor is."

She wiped the mud off her finger.

“That’s my call. You said kill or capture — I’d say capture *hard*. But Magda, they’re wrong. I don’t know what that means yet and neither does she. So don’t let anybody close with them alone.”

*
**

Lost Isle up close is a street.

That is the thing that gets you. You can see the line of it — doorways and window-holes at chest height, a gutter, the stub of a wellhead — and it is all standing in four feet of black water with weed growing out of the windows. You walk up somebody’s road with the water at your thighs.

Nerissa went past her at the first junction and touched a doorframe as she passed, briefly, the way you touch a coffin.

The tower-stub came up out of the weed eighty feet ahead, three storeys of it still standing with one whole corner gone so you could see the floors inside like shelves.

Gardwen put her hand flat on the stone and called up it, not loud, pitched to carry that far and no further.

“**Sana.** Your aunt sent me. Nerissa sent me. She’s stood in the water at the corner and she’s got her mace and she is *extremely* angry.”

Nothing.

Then, from three floors up, very small and very hoarse:

“*Say what she calls my mother.*”

And neither of them knew.

It was the old woman who answered, and what she said was: *I don’t know, but I know you sent her an eleven page letter about a heron.*

A long silence. Long enough that Gardwen looked round.

“I don’t—” The voice broke and came back. “I don’t remember writing eleven pages.”

“You did. She’s told it to me twice tonight and she’s not a woman who repeats herself.”

Stone grit came down and landed in the water.

“Is she *really* here?”

“Aye. Stood in the channel at the corner with a mace in her belt and no robe on.”

A sound that might have been a laugh and was mostly not.

*
**

It took her a long time to come down, because she had been folded into a gap between two floor-joists for a day and a half and her legs had stopped being reliable. Twice she stopped and just breathed.

She came out into the weed-light barefoot in a school shift with her hair chopped ragged on the left side of her head, nineteen years old and looking about twelve.

Dark red hair. What was left of it.

She got hold of Gardwen's forearm and would not let go and talked in a rush, too fast, hoarse.

“There were three of them yesterday. Three. There's only been two since this morning — the other one went off in the boat before dawn and hasn't come back—”

“Slow down, lass.”

“You don't understand.” She was shaking. “They didn't come for me. They came for the *place*. I only ran because I *saw* — I came out to look at the ruin like everyone does and they were *already here*, and they had a girl from the school with them, and she was walking with them like she knew them.

“Bettan. Her name's Bettan. She's fourteen. She's the one they sent to the temple last night with the message.”

*
**

The old woman asked the next question, and it was a better one than anybody else in that drowned street would have thought of, and it cracked the whole thing open.

How well do you know this girl? Did she change recently?

Sana made herself stop shaking to answer it properly, because she is clever.

“About a month ago. She was — Bettan’s a *baby*. Fourteen and homesick and cries at everything, and she’d got herself half-drowned in the misery of it, and none of us were kind enough about it. Then she went quiet for about a week. Properly quiet, wouldn’t come down to meals, and Mistress Corliss had her in and we all thought she’d be sent home.

“And then she came back *cheerful*.

“That’s the bit. Not better — *cheerful*. And she started being lovely to everyone. Girls she’d never spoken to. She sat with Ana Vell for a whole week and Ana Vell is *horrible*. We all said it was nice. Mistress Corliss said it was nice. Everyone was so pleased.”

Then her voice dropped.

“She stopped wearing her shawl. In *February*. She’d sit in the window bay with the shutter open at night doing her letters and the rest of us are three to a bed with chilblains, and she’d say she was warm.

“And she started asking about people’s families. All the time. Who’s your mother, where’s your house, have you got sisters. And we all told her, because she was being *nice*.”

She looked at the ragged side of her own head.

“She did my hair. Three weeks ago. She said she could do the plait my aunt does and she stood behind me with the scissors and she did it *beautifully*, and I said thank you.”

CHAPTER 15 — A REASON TO STOP



THE TWO MEN WERE SITTING SIDE BY SIDE ON THE EDGE OF A SLAB IN THE DARK and they had been sitting there without speaking for twenty minutes, and it was Nerissa who put a name to what that meant.

“Two men who have sat in the dark without speaking for twenty minutes are waiting for something.”

Magda went up the drowned street alone with the staff across her body and the water pushing at her thighs. Past the punt in its doorway with a young Sword folded down beside it who did not look up as she passed. Sixty yards.

Then the big room. Half a roof, no wall on the water side, so she could see straight in from thirty feet: a stone floor above the waterline, a raised slab, and a heap of dragged-up weed and muck stacked against the standing wall. Where they had cleared it there was cut stone showing, deep-carved, and the carving went on down under the water at the edge, and it was a great deal older than anything else on that island.

The red-slide lantern sat on the slab, shut.

And the two of them were sitting on the edge of it, facing the water, facing her, in the dark.

She was twenty feet away before either moved.

Then both of them turned their heads at once. Not together, like men who heard the same thing. *At once* — the same speed, the same distance, like two doors on one hinge.

Neither stood.

One of them — sandy, thirties, a boatman's forearms — said in an entirely ordinary voice:

"You're not her."

And the other one, without any pause at all, in the same voice, finished it:

"—she was meant to bring the girl."

*
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"No girl," Magda said. "Just little old me. All alone surrounded by big scary warriors."

And the stone went out on the last word.

It took the sandy one high on the right arm, on the outside, and she *heard* the bone go from twenty feet.

The arm dropped. It did not swing. It simply stopped being part of him and hung there.

He did not make a sound. He did not look at it. He did not look at her.

Both of them stood up at the same moment, at the same speed, as if the slab had tipped them.

And the sandy one said, conversationally, with his arm hanging off him:

"That's going to make the poling difficult."

And the other one finished: "—we'll manage."

*
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What followed took about a minute and a half and Magda has been in enough fights to know that it was not really a fight, it was a discovery.

She parried the billhook and rolled her wrists and took it out of his hands and put it in the water, and he watched it go with mild interest. She pivoted and put everything she had into the sandy one's ruined arm and took it apart again below the elbow, so that what was hanging off his shoulder had bone through the sleeve, six inches of it.

He went back one step from the force of it. Then he straightened up.

He looked at the ruin of his own arm — and this time he *did* look at it, curiously, turning slightly to see it better, the way you would inspect a torn coat.

And the other one, standing empty-handed in the water beside him, said: "That's the arm gone, then."

"Mm," said the sandy one.

Neither of them had bled a drop.

Then Gardwen came out of the dark forty yards up the drowned street at a dead run with the wolf ahead of her, and Ruhi took the billhook-man off his feet into the black, and the two of them went under together in a boil of white — and he did not thrash and he did not come up for air, because he did not need any. He simply got a hand in the wolf's ruff and began, methodically, to work it deeper.

Magda brought six feet of seasoned ash down into the boil with her whole weight behind it and the water took nearly all of it, which is what water does, and it landed on the back of his skull like dropping a log. It should not have been enough for anything. But it *did* something, because for the first time all night one of them made a movement that was not smooth, and the hand loosened, and Ruhi got her hindquarters under her and came backwards out of his grip with a great sheet of water and half his sleeve.

He sat up with the back of his head split and no expression at all and said:

"Oh — that was the wolf, was it."

And Gardwen put her hand out flat toward the sandy one and said three words in the old tongue, and the water between them went still in a ring, and he stopped mid-step with his weight forward and the ruined arm still swinging gently from the momentum he had a second before.

His eyes went on moving. Something in him was furious about it and none of it reached his face.

“Ohhh,” he said. Just that. Perfectly pleasant.

Gardwen had gone white.

“It shouldn’t hold,” she said. “Magda — that’s *Hold Person*. There shouldn’t be enough person in him to grip.”

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The other one got hold of Magda in the end and would not let go, and Ruhi took his leg out from under him, and because he would not let go she went down into the black with him. He lay on the bottom of a drowned street holding her forearm, not struggling, not pushing her down, simply waiting, because he did not need to breathe and he had all night.

Her face was about eight inches under.

Gardwen put everything she had into one word and the hand opened — all four fingers at once, like a catch releasing — and Magda came up off the bottom into air and lamplight coughing canal.

He sat up beside her with his hands open in his lap, palms turned upward, and looked at them.

“That wasn’t me,” he said, with what might almost have been interest.

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And here is the part that is not a fight story.

He got up. He did not come at her again. He waded, unhurried, toward the slab and the uncovered stone behind it, with his hands still

open at his sides — and Nerissa was between him and it, and she did not move, and neither did he.

They looked at each other across four feet of black water.

Then he said: "You're the Lady's, aren't you."

"I am."

"Good," he said. "She'll want to see this."

And he stepped sideways, out of her path, and gestured with an open hand at the cut stone they had spent a day digging out of the weed.

Magda came out of the water and planted her back foot in the mud and swung the way you swing at a fence post that has offended you.

Six feet of ash across the temple. Nothing between it and the bone.

His head went sideways past where a head goes. He dropped straight down where he stood, with no stagger, and the water took him and closed over.

The body did not float.

Nerissa did not move. She was standing exactly where she had been, mace up, four feet away, with her mouth slightly open.

She lowered the mace slowly.

"He had stopped," she said. Not accusing. Just stating it, the way a woman reads a figure back to check she has it right. "He had stopped, and he was showing me the stone."

*
**

Magda went for the other one next. The held one. The one who could not move.

She broke his good arm with the staff while he was frozen and could not flinch, and he watched the staff come down and go back up and there was nothing behind his eyes at all, and he said, "You've done that twice now."

Nerissa came through the water and stopped beside her. She was careful not to take hold of her arm.

“Magda.” Very level. “The other one had put his hands down. I don’t say you were wrong — I don’t know what these things are and neither do you. But I will not stand here and watch you take a helpless man apart piece by piece, so tell me plainly what you want him for, and then we’ll do that thing and stop.”

And Magda, from somewhere a long way down inside the noise, said the only true thing available to her:

I’m a berserker. That means I fight until someone convinces me to stop.

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Nerissa has spent thirty years in a room where people lie to her, and she has been watching this woman since midnight, and she read her completely.

Whatever she had been going to say next, she did not say it.

She changed her footing. She stopped standing like a woman about to remonstrate and started standing like a woman at the side of a horse that is still running.

“Ah,” she said. Very quietly. “Ah. You’re not deciding anything, are you.”

She lowered the mace all the way and let it hang.

“I’ve seen this twice. Once in a man at the Shoals after a fire, and once in my own father.” Her voice stayed completely even — not soothing, not raised, the pace of somebody reading a list. “You’re not cruel. You’ve simply not been given a reason to stop yet, and nobody in this water has thought to give you one. They’ve only told you to.”

She moved round until she was in front of her rather than beside her, slowly, so that Magda could see her do it.

“So. Here’s the reason.

“Sana is in a boat forty yards behind us, nineteen years old, with her hair cut off, watching. That girl has spent a day and a half in a hole in the dark being brave, and what she can see from there is an old woman breaking a man who can’t move.

“That’s it. That’s the whole reason. Not the man — he’s nothing to me and I’d hang him tomorrow. **Her.**”

She held out one open hand. Not to take the staff. Just open.

Magda did not answer, and she did not lower the staff either.

She just stopped.

Water running off her, breathing like a bellows, everything in her face still exactly where it had been — and standing entirely still in the middle of it, which is not the same thing as being calm, and everybody there knew the difference.

Nobody asked her for the staff. Nerissa did not move her hand away and did not reach any closer.

Corvin and Ash roped the prisoner in silence, working around the ruined arm rather than through it, which was more care than Magda would have taken.

And when the ring of stillness let go and the man came back to life mid-step and found himself trussed and sitting, he looked up, and found her, and smiled for the first time all night.

“You’re the one who did the boy in the canal,” he said. “The face like a spade. He described you before he went.”

CHAPTER 16 — THE MAN WHO SAID YES TO A COAT



IT WAS NOT A SLAB. NERISSA GOT THE LAMP FULL OPEN AND HELD IT OUT OVER THE cleared patch and what they had spent a day digging out of the weed turned out to be the top of a stair.

Four steps showing, cut into the same worked stone, going down at an angle and disappearing into black water that did not reflect the lamp the way the rest of the channel did. Weed hanging off the edges where it had been hacked away.

And the steps were *swept*. There was no silt on them, and there should have been a foot of it.

Something had been using them.

Nerissa went down on her knees in the water beside it with the lamp held low and put both palms on the carving and closed her eyes, and she could tell them exactly what it *did* and not one thing about what it *meant*, and you could watch that bother her more than the corpse in the water.

“It’s a door. Not for people. For the drowned.”

She traced the carving with two fingers, following it down, and her hand went under the surface and kept going.

“There are old stories about the Northern Isles going under. Not one flood — a slow one, over generations, and everything in them that died went down with the streets. And whoever cut this cut it so that what stayed in the water had somewhere to go. A way out. You lay them to rest through a thing like this.”

She looked up, and there was something urgent in it.

“It isn’t a Lady-stone. It’s older than her presence in this channel and it isn’t in any doctrine I’ve read in forty years, and I could not tell you who cut it or to what.”

Behind them, roped and sitting in the shallows, the prisoner said pleasantly:

“That’s what he went to fetch the boat for. You’d best hurry — he’s been gone since before dawn, and he’ll not be coming back alone.”

*

**

His name was Ellick Sarn, and he had to think about it, which was the unsettling part.

“Ellick,” he said at last. “Ellick Sarn. That’s — yes. That’s right, I’m fairly sure. I poled the Forge Quarter run. Timber mostly, sometimes charcoal, and a woman called Tam who I think was—”

He stopped. Frowned very slightly at the sky.

“There was something about Tam. It’s gone.”

The boat creaked. Ash rowed. Nobody had told him to start again and nobody told him to stop.

“They came to me in the winter. Not the young lord — the *quiet* one, him that’s gone for the boat. He asked did I know the Northern Isles and I said better than any man breathing, which was true, and he paid me eleven marks to take him out to the drowned streets four times and say nothing. I did say nothing. I want that noted. I kept my end.”

“And then?”

“And then on the fourth time he said, would I like to not be cold any more.”

He said it perfectly evenly.

“I’ve been cold on that water for thirty-one years, missus. Every winter. Hands gone the colour of the sky. And he said it like he was offering me a coat.”

His head tipped a little.

“And I said yes. That’s the part everyone wants to skip past. Nobody did anything to me that I didn’t stand still for.”

Sana had both hands over her mouth.

“What went in you?”

“Something out of the stairs.” A shrug that moved the whole trussed body oddly. “It’s not unkind. It doesn’t want anything much. It likes the digging.” He considered it. “It’s got a lot more of me than it had at Candlemas. That’s the trade — it warms you and it *wears* you, and you don’t notice the wearing because the part that would notice is the part it’s wearing.”

Then, conversationally:

“You’ll be wanting to know about the one on the ship. That’s a different thing entirely. That one’s *furnished*.”

*
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He told them the rest because he was asked and because he had no particular reason not to, with the flat helpfulness of a man giving directions.

The quiet one wants the door open. That is the whole of the digging. Four days, and it wants to be open before the Tourney and not after — he was very hard about that. There is a tide thing in it. He said something about the water being *thin* on the day and it having to be while it is thin.

Nerissa’s head came round at that. “He said *thin*?”

“His word.”

And the door is for taking something *out*.

“That’s the bit I did understand, because I asked him — I said is this for putting things in, like you did with me, and he laughed. Only time I saw him laugh. He said no, Ellick, that’s the easy way and any fool with a knife can do that. He said the hard thing is getting one *out* whole and putting it somewhere better.

“Because you can’t keep a thing in a boy for ever. He said that too. They wear through. He said the one they’ve got has nearly used up what it was put in.”

He turned his head and looked at Gardwen for the first time.

“That’s why they came here. It’s not a rescue they’re worried about, love. It’s a *removal*. He’s outgrown the boy and they’ve somewhere better to put him.”

And Sana, very quietly, from the far thwart:

“...The girls with the red hair aren’t for the demon. They’re spares.”

*
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And then, at last, the name.

“Mine’s *content*, see. It got a boatman who was cold and it’s warm now and it likes lifting stone. There’s no fight in it. That’s why I’m still able to sit here and talk to you about Tam and nearly remember her.”

He nodded north-west, toward where the black hull sat steaming at its pier.

“That one *figh*ts.”

Ash stopped rowing. Nobody told him to start.

“I was aboard twice, carrying. You can hear it through the deck. Not screaming — worse than that, it’s *arguing*. Goes on for hours. Two voices out of one throat having a row, and one of them’s a boy and one of them isn’t, and the one that isn’t sounds like a man who’s been told to do something he thinks is dishonourable.”

He shook his head slowly.

“That’s what the morning cut’s for. It’s not just the wear. It’s to keep it *tired*. You bleed a man to keep him from arguing.

“They’ve a name for it. Old-sounding. The quiet one says it like a title, not a name.” He worked his jaw, hunting for it. “Thoo— *Thuban*. Thuban something. Eta, maybe. He’s a knight out of the dragon wars and he’s been in one thing or another for a very long while, and he doesn’t want to be, and he never has.”

He looked around the boat at all of them.

“You keep saying *rescue the boy*. I’d think about that. There’s two in there, and only one of them’s been asking to get out.”

*
**

Nobody rowed. The boat drifted.

Nerissa said it first, slowly, the way you read something off a wall.

“Eleven nights. A knight in dragon-scale who is already dead and does not know it.” She turned to look at Magda. “And *lay the dragon warrior to rest*. Not the boy. She never once showed you the boy.

“She showed you the **passenger**.”

Her hand had gone to her breast.

“Magda — your goddess has been telling you the answer since before you left home and none of us could hear it because we were all looking at the child.”

Gardwen had gone absolutely still in the bow.

“Say the rest of it,” she said. “Say it out loud so I’ve heard it.”

Nerissa did.

“If Thuban Eta is laid to rest, he leaves. And whatever is left in that body is your brother, and only your brother.” A pause. “It is not a rescue. It’s a *funeral*. And the boy walks out of it because the funeral wasn’t for him.”

Ellick, helpfully, into the silence:

“That’s what the door’s for, mind. Same door. Only the quiet one wants him lifted *out and moved*, and you want him lifted out and let go. You’ll be wanting the same night and the same stair as him, then. And the same thin water.”

And Magda, who had understood perhaps a third of it, said so, and Nerissa stopped using her temple voice and explained it on three fingers like a woman laying out a cart’s load; and at the end of it Gardwen said, without turning round:

“And either way my brother comes out of it empty. Alive, and empty, and his own.”

“Told you it was a funeral,” said Ellick.

The sky over the Forge Quarter had gone properly grey.

One day. The Tourney was tomorrow.

CHAPTER 17 — NOBODY EVER CAME BACK



THORNE HAS SAT IN THE SAME CORNER OF THE MOIST OYSTER FOR ELEVEN YEARS and buys nobody a drink, and there is a widely held view in that house that he is a harmless old man who tells stories, which he has worked extremely hard to encourage.

He was Order of the Lake for thirty-one years before he was not, and they do not throw you out of that for nothing.

He watched her cross the room and he had her before she reached the table.

The mail under the borrowed cloak. The mud on the hem. The particular grey-green weed dried on her boot that grows in exactly one place in this city.

He moved his cup six inches to the left, which is an invitation, and said:

“Sit down, mother. You’ve had a night.”

She had not said a word yet.

“Two nights, at a guess. One of them wet. One of them worse.

“I’ll tell you what *I’ve* had, since you’re wondering. I’ve had a girl in here at seven this morning saying Constantine’s house has a physician in it and won’t say why. I’ve had a lad off Renko’s cart telling anyone who’ll listen that some old woman knows about horses. And about an

hour ago I had two of the Baron's people asking whether anybody's seen a big northern woman with a face like a spade."

He looked up.

"I said no. I'd like it noted that I said no *before* I knew what I was saying no about, which is the sort of thing I'll want paying for eventually."

*

**

She offered to pay him to tell them yes, and then to tell them a few other things besides, and Thorne put his hand flat on the table and stopped her.

Because people never understand what they are buying, and he has got tired of finding out afterwards.

"You've just offered to pay me to tell a man a lie.

"I don't sell lies, mother. I sell *stories*, and the difference is that a story has to hold up when it's repeated by an idiot in a different tavern three days later. You can't just hand me a falsehood and a coin. You have to give me something that has the *shape* of true.

"A lie collapses. A story goes and gets *itself* believed."

Two conditions, and they are not negotiable. He will not put a name on anybody who would hang for it — if the story wants a body it uses a dead one or a made-up one, never a living neighbour. And he is told what it is *for*, not everything, but enough that if it goes wrong he knows whether he ought to be sorry.

"Meet those and my price is small and strange: I want the *true* version. Afterwards. All of it, in order, told to me once and never written down.

"So. What do you want Blau to hear?"

*

**

And then she did the thing that nobody ever does.

She gave him the true one first.

A randy young nobleman carves up a courtesan to put a lust-demon in her, gets the charm right and botches the escape, falls in the canal and catches a slingshot to the temple.

Thorne went very still while she talked. When she had finished he did not say anything for a while. He turned the chalk over three times.

“You’ve just done the thing nobody ever does,” he said at last. “You’ve handed me the *true* one first.”

He was, if he is honest, faintly offended by how well it worked.

“And it’s better than anything I’d have built, because every part of it is checkable. There *is* a physician at Constantine’s. There *are* four houses on the Pearl that won’t take di Teufel coin by tonight once the Pearl hears why. There *was* a young lord in that house on the night, and there are eleven people who saw him come in and none who saw him leave.

“That’s not a story I have to sell. That’s a story that sells itself house to house and comes back to me by Thursday with improvements.”

Then he held up a finger.

“But you’ve a problem in it and you’ve walked straight past it. The truest version has an old northern woman with a sling in it. And there is a man on a ship asking after an old northern woman with a face like a spade.

“So here’s the craft of it. Everything you told me stays *exactly as it is*. And the stone comes out of nowhere.

“He fell in the canal and *the water took him*, and the Lady’s channel does not care for demon-work, and a man who profanes a Pearl house with a lust-demon and then goes into the sacred water — well.” He spread his hands. “That’s not even a lie, is it. That’s a *sermon*. Half this city will believe it before I’ve finished saying it, and the other half will believe it harder because the temple hasn’t denied it.”

He finally drank.

“As for how I feel about the good Baron.” Something moved behind his face. “I was Order of the Lake for thirty-one years, mother. I know what a stair under Lost Isle is for. You didn’t mention one. You didn’t have to — you’ve got weed on your boot that only grows in the drowned streets, and you came in here asking about the dead.

“Tell me I’m wrong.”

*
**

She laughed and said he was not wrong, and gave him the rest of it, and nudged the girl into telling hers.

Gardwen told it the way she told Marisette, with no shape to it. Nine of them. The counting in the morning. The brother who was not there.

And then the name.

Thorne put the chalk down.

“Say that again.”

“Thuban Eta. The knight in the boy.”

*
**

Here is a thing about being Order of the Lake for thirty-one years. There is a great deal of it you can put down afterwards, and a small amount that is simply in you, and one of the things that is simply in Thorne is the second-year lesson about the Eta company.

“Thuban Eta was real. That’s not a story name. That’s a *muster roll* name.

“The Dragon Kings had knight-companies, and the Eta were one of them — the letter’s a company mark, not a family. And Thuban is the one they teach you about in your second year, because of how he died.

“He wouldn’t burn a town. That’s the whole of it. The company was ordered to fire a valley and he refused, and argued it in front of the others, and about a third of them came round to him. So the ones

who hadn't took him out on the water at night to talk it over, and they put him over the side in his mail with his hands tied.

"Drowned. By his own company. For refusing an order that even *they* thought was filthy — that's the part that damns them. They knew he was right and they killed him for making them know it."

He looked up.

"And that is *exactly* the kind of dead man you can bind. You don't hold a shade with iron, mother. You hold it with the thing it can't put down." He tapped his own chest. "You keep him in the moment of it. Tied hands and cold water and his own men's faces looking down at him — you keep him *there*, and he'll pull against it for a hundred years and never once get out, and every time he pulls you can use the pulling."

Gardwen said, very low: "That's what's in my brother."

"That's what's in your brother. And it has been for ten years, and it has hated every hour of it, because a man who wouldn't fire a valley is not going to enjoy being made into a champion."

He pushed the chalk away.

"Your goddess said *lay him to rest*, and everyone at this table has been thinking that means a door and a ritual. It might not. You don't lay that man down with a stair.

"You lay him down by *undoing the betrayal*. By someone standing in front of him and taking it back on behalf of the ones who did it.

"The door gets him out of the boy. Something else has to make him *willing to go*."

*
**

The old woman told him he was mad.

Which is fair, and is the correct response, and he was pleased with her for it.

That was a thousand years ago. Who the fuck could do that now? The kings themselves and all their armies were laid to rest. Every child knows that.

"You're right," Thorne agreed. "There's no company left to answer for it and no descendants worth the name. If it wants the *actual men*, it's impossible and we may as well go home."

He held up a finger.

"But that's not how a debt like that works. It never wanted the men. It's been a thousand years — Thuban knows they're dust. What holds him isn't a grudge against nine specific bastards.

"It's that **nobody ever came back for him**.

"He went over the side and the water closed and that was the end, and no company, no order, no god, no sister — *nobody* has stood over that water since and said 'this was wrong, and he was ours, and we're taking him home.'"

And then the druid girl said the thing that finished it, slowly, in a voice she had not used all night.

"There's a thing we do in the wood, for a beast that's died badly. In a snare, or under a fall, where it couldn't get free. You don't pray it away. You go and you *sit* with it, and you say out loud that it wasn't right, and then you carry it. That's the whole rite. Somebody has to actually pick the thing up.

"It doesn't need the ones who did it. It needs somebody willing to *stand where they stood* and answer for it. Not because it's theirs — because they're the one who turned up."

Thorne let that sit exactly as long as it deserved.

Then he laid his card down.

"And who exactly do we know that serves the god of the ones nobody sings about?

"Not the battle-dead, you said. The other kind. In the bed, in the byre, in the bad winter. A knight drowned in the dark by his own

friends for refusing to burn a village, and left out of every song since, in every land, for a thousand years.

“Mother — whose *is* he, if he isn’t hers?”

*
**

Nobody said anything for a moment.

Then the old woman said “Fuck me,” and then “Hel,” and then, with the particular exhausted affection of a woman who has been outmanoeuvred by her own deity:

“The old lady has her ways. OK. I’ll do it.”

Thorne picked up his cup and finally drank from it properly, like a man closing a ledger.

“Well,” he said. “There it is.”

*
**

And then, before she left, she took her kettle helm off and set it on the table and leaned in across the cup and put her forehead against his.

Gently. For her.

There was still an audible knock.

Thorne sat back with his eyes watering slightly and a hand going to his brow, and he was not displeased at all.

“*Ohh*,” he said. “That’s a northern thing.”

“That’s a northern thing.”

“I’ve read about that.” He worked his jaw. “It reads considerably better than it feels.”

The girl mopping had stopped mopping. The dog under the table had reconsidered its position entirely. Gardwen had put her face in her hand.

Thorne straightened his collar with enormous dignity.

“Thirty-one years in the Order, two of them at the Governor’s table, and no one has ever done that to me. I’ve been given a chain of office and a commendation from a Prince and neither of them landed like that.”

He picked the chalk back up.

“Go on then. Get out of my corner.”

And as she was standing, without looking up:

“Mother. When they ask me this morning — and they will — I’m going to say I’ve never seen you.

“That’s on the house.”

CHAPTER 18 — TERMS



CROWBILL IS WIRY AND FORGETTABLE AND WOULD BE INVISIBLE IN ANY CROWD IN the world except for a small crow inked on the back of his right hand, and he was eating bread and cheese off a paper at his desk when they brought the pig woman in, and he did not stop.

“The pig woman,” he said. “Sit down. You’ve had a busy two days and I’ve heard four versions and none of them agree about the wolf.”

He took another bite.

“Go on, then.”

She asked him whether he had ever wondered what was on the Baron’s ship.

“Every day since it tied up,” he said. “That’s not a boast, that’s my *trade*. A foreign lord brings a deep-water hull into a canal city and moors it at a private pier and lets nobody aboard — of course I’ve thought about what’s on it. So has every fence between here and the Shoals.”

He wiped his fingers on the paper.

“And here’s why it’s still sat there with everything on it.

“**One:** ten men in scale and one way up. **Two:** it’s a *ship*, so if it goes badly they don’t have to win, they just have to cast off, and then

I've lost people for nothing. **Three** —" he held up the third finger and looked at her over it "— a Baron. Not a merchant, not a guild. A man with a border tower and three hundred men and a long memory, who would spend two years and a lot of money finding out who did it, because that's what men like him are *for*."

He sat back.

"Which is three good reasons, and you didn't come here without knowing them. So you've got something that answers all three, or you wouldn't have got past my door.

"So let's not do the part where you sell it to me. Just tell me the two things I actually need. When is she sailing? And what do you want off her that isn't cargo?"

*
**

She told him. Tonight, and everything on that ship is out of this city for ever after that. And what she wanted off it was the champion.

Crowbill put the bread down.

He has been reading people across that desk for twenty years and he could not read her, and he said so, because it was true and because it was the sort of thing that tells the other party something useful about your position.

"See, now, that's a strange thing to want, and I can usually tell when someone's shading me and I can't tell with you, which I don't enjoy." He tapped the desk twice with one knuckle. The crow moved. "The cargo I understand. Cargo is cargo. But the fighting man is the one item on that ship the Baron will actually *chase*. Gold he replaces. A champion the day before the Lady's Tourney? That's him publicly beaten in front of every Guild in this city.

"So you're not asking me to rob a lord. You're asking me to *humiliate* one, and put my name on it, in exchange for goods I'd have to fence quietly for a year."

He leaned back.

“So here’s my question, and I want the true answer, because I’m not putting forty men on a pier for a story.

“What’s wrong with him?”

“Nobody hides a swordsman. You hide a thing that would *lose you everything* if it were seen. And whatever it is, it’s coming into my city on my boats and I’ll be the one holding it.”

*
**

“It’s not a humiliation,” she said. “It’s a rescue.”

And then she told him, flatly, with no arrangement to it: a general dead a thousand years, put into the body of that young woman’s brother, bled every morning to keep him quiet.

“Seventeen,” Gardwen said quietly, from the side.

Crowbill looked at her, and then back at the old woman, and did not say anything for a while.

Then: “A boy with a dead general in him.”

“Aye.”

“Being kept on a ship for it.”

“Bled every morning to keep him quiet. There’s a laundress on that pier who’s been boiling the sheets for five days and can tell you the shape of the cut.”

He stood. He went to the window, which looks at a wall, and stood there with his hands behind his back.

“I’ve a rule,” he said to the wall. “I’ve a few. Most of them are about money and one of them isn’t, and the one that isn’t is why I’ve still got a city to work in.

“Children aren’t stock. You don’t sell them, you don’t use them, and you don’t let anyone do it on my water and call it business.”

He turned round.

“Your Marisette knows that rule. It’s why we get on.”

He came back to the desk and did not sit.

“So. I’d have done it for the cargo anyway. Now I’ll do it *properly*, which is different, and here are my terms — and they’re not money.

“**One.** Everything on that ship that isn’t the boy is mine, and nobody counts it but me.

“**Two.** My name is nowhere. Not in the temple’s version, not in your storyteller’s, not in a Governor’s warrant if you ever get one. Tonight was *thieves*, and this city has plenty.

“**Three** — and this is the one I care about.”

He put one finger on the desk.

“When it’s done and the boy’s out and whatever you’re doing with the ghost is done, the High Priestess of the Lake Lady stands up and says publicly that the canal folk kept her water clean. Not me. Not names. *The canal folk*.

“Because I have four hundred people who get moved on and blamed and dredged out of the channel, and one sentence from that woman is worth more to them than a Baron’s whole hold.”

He raised an eyebrow.

“Can you get me that?”

*
**

Then he asked the practical question, which is how forty poled men are supposed to get past ten men in scale up one ramp, having already explained that this is how people die.

And the old woman said: “You’re the river men, I’m just a pig farmer.”

And then she said the thing that made his face become interested for the first time in the conversation.

“She has to leave to sail. Once she’s off that pier she’s not got four men at the bollards and four at a ramp — she’s just a hull in the dark with a channel round her, and the channel’s yours.”

“It is.” He was already pulling a scrap of paper over. “And she cannot get out to sea without going through the **Mouth**, and the Mouth on the ebb is a mile of slow water with the harbour lights behind it, and I have men who have been going up the sides of anchored hulls in that stretch since they were nine years old.”

He drew.

“You don’t need forty. You need *twelve*, in six punts with no lights, and you take her from three sides at once while she’s making way and everyone aboard is looking forward.

“And the best of it — a ship under way has half her people at the ropes and the rest looking where she’s *going*. Nobody watches a wake.”

Then he stopped drawing.

“One problem, and it’s yours to solve, not mine.”

He tapped the waterline on his own sketch.

“That hull *steams*. Whatever your Baron’s got in her, it cooks the water where it touches, and there’s a dead slick round her the whole way out. I’ve had a man put his hand in that water off the stern two days ago on a dare and he’s still got no feeling in three fingers.

“My people go up the outside of hulls. They cannot climb *that* one — not at the waterline, and that’s where you have to start.

“So. Between the lot of you, can anybody make forty feet of that hull cold enough to touch for the four minutes it takes to get twelve men over the rail?”

*
**

Gardwen ruled herself out immediately, which she was right to do — she does bark and bones and bleeding and could not cool a kettle — and then named the two who could, and what each would cost.

Nerissa could try. It is her channel and that hull is wounding it, and she felt it go thin from a mile off. But she had already gone past what she was sure of once that day. She would be doing it from a boat, in the

dark, in a moving channel, against something that had been fouling her water for five days.

“Meaning she’d probably do it and it’d probably cost her more than she’d tell us.”

And then the other lot, that nobody had said out loud yet.

“The Mermaid’s Court. Their chambers are *under Lost Isle*. We’ve been standing on the roof of them all night and the only reason nothing came up those stairs at us is that nothing chose to.”

Crowbill set his pen down.

“**Ravella**. Siren’s Call. Half of one and half of us, and she brokers for them when they can be bothered to want anything. I’ve done business with her twice and both times I came off worse and knew it at the time.”

He looked up.

“She’d be able to. Water that’s been made wrong is exactly their complaint, and that hull’s been bleeding into their front hall for five days.”

A shrug.

“But you’d be asking the Court for a favour, mother. They don’t take coin and they don’t take gratitude. They take *arrangements*.”

*
**

Ravella came into the little room off the landing stage at the Siren’s Call ten minutes after Crowbill’s name got them into it. Handsome, forty-ish, unhurried, faint scales at the hairline that could be a trick of the light, and fingers very slightly webbed which she made no attempt to hide, which is itself a statement about who she thinks you are.

“You’re the pig woman. You’ve had a remarkable two days and I’ve heard *nine* versions.” She pushed a cup across. “Crowbill sent you, which means you want something from under the water. So let’s save an hour: what do you want, and what have you got that the Court might conceivably care about?”

The old woman said: “The demonologist Hanzo di Teufel and his festering shitpile of a barge.”

Ravella’s cup stopped halfway to her mouth. She set it down without drinking.

“Say the rest.”

And when she had heard it, the broker’s smile went off her face entirely and what was underneath it was much older and much less friendly.

“Let me tell you what ‘thin’ means from underneath, since nobody up here ever asks.

“There are people living in the deep channels of this city who were here before the causeway. Not many. They keep out of the way and they mind their own business and their whole lives are *water that behaves*. And for five days there has been a hot wound in the eastern channel that pushes ahead of the tide, and every one of them has had to move — old, young, sick — and two haven’t managed it.”

She said the last part very flatly. Outside the window the canal had gone glassy in a strip about four feet wide.

“So yes. We mind.”

Then she picked the cup up again and the broker came back, which was somehow worse.

“But you’d have got that from a fishwife. Here’s the part you’d have paid for.

“They came down our stairs.

“Under Lost Isle. Four days ago, three men with a lantern, digging out a door that has been left shut and unmarked since before this city had a name. And they *took* things off it — the small confused ones that sit near the threshold and don’t go through, which are ours to look after and nobody else’s.

“The Court could not stop them. Won’t say why and I’ve stopped asking. So we have had our water burned and our threshold robbed in

the same week, and we have been able to do precisely nothing about either.

“And now an old woman walks into my house smelling of Lost Isle weed with a dead captain’s axe.

“How many of the taken have you seen?”

“Two.”

“Where.”

“One’s dead. I put an axe through his head on Lost Isle last night and he went face-down in the drowned street and didn’t float. The other’s roped in a cellar under the Lake Lady’s temple with two Swords on the door, and he talks. Boatman. Ellick Sarn.”

Something passed over her face at the name and she did not explain it.

“Ellick. He poled the Forge Quarter run. He carried for us twice.”

She was quiet for a moment.

“Then you already have both of them and you didn’t know what you had.”

She sat back.

“Here is the arrangement, and I’ll speak for the Court because they’ll agree and because there isn’t time to go down and ask.

“Give them back.

“That’s the whole price. Not the ship, not the Baron, not your boy — those are your business and the Court doesn’t care about a dead general or a barony. The two you’ve got are *ours*, and they need to go back through that threshold and be let go properly, and until they are they’re neither ours nor dead nor alive, and that is an obscenity.”

She looked at her very directly.

“You should understand what you’re agreeing to. The thing in Ellick Sarn came off our threshold and it goes back to it. What’s left of Ellick is —” a pause, and she chose the word carefully “— *thin*. There

isn't a version of this where a boatman walks home to his supper. He said yes to a warm coat in a cold winter and he has been paying for it ever since, and the kindest end available to him is the right one.

"You'd be taking him to that stair and standing there while it's done."

She turned her cup again.

"And I understand that's your trade."

Then, briskly, the broker again:

"Do that, and I will come out to the Mouth myself tonight and put my hands on that hull and make it cold enough to climb. For as long as you need, not four minutes. And I will bring people who can be in the water beside it while it happens, which your Crowbill's boys cannot.

"Two dead men, laid down properly, for one cold ship. Do we have an arrangement?"

"Don't know where the second one is," said the old woman. "But sure. I'll do what I can."

Ravella took her hand anyway. Her grip was cool and slightly damp and a great deal stronger than it looked.

"You don't need to know where he is. He went into a drowned street off Lost Isle with an axe wound in his head and did not float. He's in our water. We'll have him on that threshold by dark and you won't have to look for him — you'll have to *stand* there, which is the part that matters."

She stood and smoothed her dress.

"I'll be at the Mouth from the eighth bell with four of mine. And Magda — when you're standing over those two tonight, say it out loud. Whatever your goddess's words are.

"The Court will be listening from underneath and they will want to hear that somebody up here said it."

*
**

Nerissa's answer came back across the water in her own square hand, on a scrap of paper the size of a palm, carried by a gondolier who would have done it for nothing.

*Tell the crow he shall have his sentence — from the temple steps, at the Tourney, in front of the Governor and every Guild in this city. **The canal folk kept the Lady's water clean.** Those words, that place, and I will not soften them.*

I would have said it years ago if anyone had thought to ask me. That he had to buy it is a shame on my order, not on him.

— V.

CHAPTER 19 — THE REVERSAL



HESPER HAD NOT LEFT THAT GREEN ROOM IN THIRTY HOURS AND WHEN HE FINALLY came out of it he had the expression of a man who has just told a demon that he will be back shortly and been told *of course you will, dear*.

He had bought it a syllable at a time and he laid it out in a passage on the Pearl with the door shut behind him.

“You cannot simply pull a shade out and let it go. It has to have somewhere to be, even for a moment, or it goes into the nearest living thing standing over it — which will be one of you.

“So a removal needs three parts. The door. The *thing it comes out of*. And the **anchor** — something that already holds a piece of him, that he’ll consent to sit in while he’s between.”

He looked at her.

“The Baron carries a locket. It’s the small anchor, the working one, and he’s had it on his person since before they left the border. That’s what keeps the daily ritual holding.

“But that’s not the primary. And the thing in that room told me what is, this morning, while complaining about how much *nicer* it would be to have a proper one.”

He took a breath.

“They’ve got his bones. Thuban’s. In the Baron’s border tower, where they’ve been for a hundred years, because you cannot hold a man like that with anything less.”

Magda laughed. It was not a good laugh.

“Well. How the fuck are we going to do that?”

*
**

Hesper did not laugh back. He looked at her for a moment and then something happened behind his eyes.

“Wait. Say the bit about the quiet one again. The timing.”

“Gone since before dawn yesterday. Ellick reckoned four hours out to the border tower and four back with a fair wind.”

“And it’s been thirty-six.”

His hands came up.

“So he is not *at* the tower. He has been there, and he is on his way *back*, and he is late because he is carrying something heavy and he will not risk it in bad water.”

Gardwen got there half a beat before Magda did.

“He’s bringing the bones *here*.”

“He has to.” Hesper was talking fast now. “They cannot do a removal without the primary anchor, and the primary anchor has sat in a border tower for a century because nobody dared move it. But they’ve run out of boy. So for the first time in a hundred years, Thuban Eta’s bones are out of that tower and on the water, and they are coming to Purewater, and they are going to the one place the work can be done.

“Which is a stair under Lost Isle that you are already sitting on with a dozen Swords of the Lake.”

Nobody said anything for a second.

Then Hesper added it, quietly, and it landed like a stone:

“And Magda — you were never going to be able to lay that man to rest without them. You know that. You’ve buried enough people.”

“You don’t put a man down without his bones.”

“No. You don’t.”

He almost smiled, and it was an awful smile, because he is a man who has just watched a problem turn inside out.

“They have spent a hundred years keeping the one thing you need locked in a tower you could never reach.

“And tonight they are rowing it to you.”

CHAPTER 20 — THE MOUTH



THE MOUTH IS A MILE OF SLOW BLACK WATER WHERE THE HARBOUR LETS OUT TO SEA with the city's lights behind you and nothing at all ahead, and the ebb had started, and you could feel the pull of it under the punt, patient and enormous.

Six punts, no lights. Crowbill's twelve were exactly what he had promised: canal men in dark wool, no armour worth the name, bare-foot, each with a short blade and a coil of line and a grapnel wrapped in sacking so it could not ring. They talked in a low register that does not carry over water. None of them had asked what was on the ship.

Crowbill himself was not there. Of course he was not.

Ravella was. She was in the bow of Magda's punt in something that was not a dress, with four of hers in the water alongside — you could not see them, but occasionally the surface did something a surface should not.

Gardwen was amidships with her staff across her knees. Ruhi would not get in the boat and was somewhere on the north bank keeping pace, which nobody had been able to prevent.

Magda was in mail, with a dead captain's axe across her back and fourteen stones in the pouch, and she had said something about not being a very good swimmer and possibly needing help, and had meant it as a joke, and it was in fact the plain truth. Swim 27 and a hauberk. If she went into that channel she was going straight to the bottom of

it. The nearest canal man grinned at her in the dark and tapped the grapnel line. *You go up from the boat, mother. Feet dry.*

*
**

Then the lights changed at the pier end of the harbour, a mile back. A lantern up and down. Another.

She had cast off.

A long time later — twenty minutes, half an hour, an age of sitting in the dark — she came down the channel under a scrap of canvas and the sweeps, unlit but for a single shaded lamp at the stern, and she was enormous close to, and even at two hundred yards you could see the white where her hull met the water and hear the *hiss* of it carrying flat across the surface.

Ravella turned round in the bow.

“When I go in, that water will kill anyone who isn’t mine for about a minute while it turns. After that it’s cold and it’s climbable and I can hold it as long as I’m conscious.” She waited. “So say when, and be sure. Because I only get to do this once tonight.”

Two hundred yards. One-fifty. A hundred. Eighty. Men on her deck, forward, looking where she was going.

“Now.”

Ravella did not answer. She went over the side without a splash and the water took her like it was expecting her.

*
**

The water went first.

You do not see her do it. What you see is the white line along that hull *stop* — forty feet of hissing steam just ceasing, mid-length, like a candle pinched out, and the dead-water slick behind it going dark and ordinary and cold.

Six punts moved at once. Grapnels went up in sacking and landed with a sound like a fist in a pillow, and canal men were on the lines

before the hooks had set, going up the side of a moving ship barefoot with knives in their teeth, and it was the most casually competent thing Magda has ever watched anybody do.

But a ship that has hissed for five days and suddenly does not is a ship that has changed its noise, and there was a man aft who had lived beside that sound long enough to notice its absence.

A voice on the quarterdeck. Not a shout. A question.

Then a shout.

Then a bell.

*
**

She did not go up the hull. She is seventy and in mail and she knew exactly what she was, which was a woman with a sling and a clear line at forty feet of rail with the sky behind it.

The first man leaned out over the side with a knife, going for the grapnel lines — which would drop three men into cold water and the ebb. Her first stone went past his head close enough that he flinched back, which bought the line about three seconds and no more.

She was already loading the next one. That is the thing about a sling. You are never really out. You are only ever between.

And the second stone was the best shot she has ever made in her life, and she would like it noted that she has no idea how.

He had turned inboard, half-lit by somebody's dropped lantern, side-on at forty feet — and the stone took him under the raised arm where the scale gapes.

He did not fall over the side. He folded sideways onto the rail with his arms over it, and the knife dropped past her into the water, and he stayed there hanging half over the edge with his legs still on the deck, which is worse for everyone aboard than if he had gone in, because now the men behind him had to get past him and the whole rail was blocked at exactly the spot they were massing.

Two more canal men went up the far line while that was happening.

*
**

Then the bell stopped. The shouting stopped. It went very quiet up there, very suddenly, which was the most frightening thing that had happened all night.

A single lantern shutter opened on the quarterdeck and swung out over the side, throwing a cone of light down onto the black water, and it began to sweep along the hull, punt by punt.

Looking for the boats. Looking for her.

The lantern made him a target and he knew it and he did it anyway, which tells you something about him.

She put a stone through the middle of him before it got there.

She *heard* it hit. Forty yards and dark and she heard it — the flat thud of a stone going into a body that has nothing on it but wool, because the man does not wear armour, because he has apparently never in his life expected to need any.

The lantern dropped. Not thrown. *Dropped*, out of a hand that had stopped working, and it went over the side and hissed out and the quarterdeck went black again.

Somewhere up there a man said something short with no breath behind it.

*
**

The rage came up out of her on the rope.

She had not let it since the woods and it does not arrive like anger. It arrives like warmth, like getting into a hot bath, everything narrowing to the next handhold and the noise above. And it is the only reason a seventy-year-old woman in a mail hauberk with an axe on her back got up forty feet of wet line at all.

She came over the rail into it.

A lantern on its side by the mainmast throwing everything sideways. Two Dragon Knights down that she could see and one canal man, face-up, not moving. The mass of it forward where the boarders had got in first — knives against scale, and the knives winning, because there are nine of them and because a man in scale on a wet deck at night is a slow, loud, obvious thing.

Aft, on the quarterdeck steps, Blau on one knee with a hand pressed flat into his own middle and the other holding the rail, and he was not out of the fight. He was *directing* it, in that voice that does not rise, and three knights were peeling back from the bow to form on him.

And behind him, under the quarterdeck, the barred shutter — from this side a door, with a beam across it and a knight standing in front of it who had not moved from that spot since the fighting started and was not going to.

Vell's axe came off her back.

*
**

She went up that deck making a noise that stopped the fighting at the bow for a full second.

It is not a war cry. It is older and uglier than that — the sound you make over a byre full of dead stock in a bad winter — and there were words somewhere in the middle of it about violators, and stealers of souls, and rapists of the dead, and every canal man on that deck decided at once that whatever that was, it was on their side.

The man in the way had a sword and a shield and it did not matter in the slightest. The axe came over the top of the shield — a size larger than it had any right to be, in hands that were not feeling the weight — and went through the scale over his belly with a sound like somebody standing on a crate. He sat down against the mast. His legs simply stopped being interested.

Eight feet to Blau.

He had watched all of that happen and his face had not changed.

"*That's her,*" he said. "The northern woman."

A pause, and something that might have been a laugh with no air behind it.

“Nobody told me she was **seventy**.”

*
**

It went badly for a while after that, and she will tell you so.

She evaded two spears and both evasions put her flat on her back on a wet deck in a hauberk, which is what evading costs and what parrying does not, and Blau — still not raising his voice, still on one knee with a hole in him — said: “Don’t crowd her. She’s on her back. Spears.”

Which is exactly the right thing to do to a downed woman with an axe.

She swung up from the deck at a knee and there was no power in it and no reach, and the axe stuck for half a second in wet oak, and a spear went into her right thigh through the mail skirt. The rage halved it. She felt the pressure of it and nothing else, the way you feel a hand on your shoulder, which is the most frightening thing about being like that.

Then Blau got off the steps.

He did it slowly, with one hand still pressed into his own middle, and the two guards moved aside for him without being told, and at three feet he looked down at her and drew a knife left-handed. A working knife. Not a duelling piece.

“You’re the pig woman.

“He was a foul little animal and he’d have been the ruin of the house inside five years.” Perfectly level. “You’ve done the Baron a service and he will hang you for it, and I’ll be there.”

He is an extremely good man with a knife and he could not make it work, because there was a hole in his abdomen that she had put there from a boat forty yards away in the dark, and every time he bent at the waist something inside him refused.

He went down onto one knee to reach her and stopped halfway with his teeth locked, and the knife came in short and slow and wide, and he had to put his other hand on the deck to keep from going over.

Neither of them touched the other.

For a second the two of them were simply face to face on a wet deck, a foot apart, both bleeding, seventy years apart in age and neither able to finish the other.

Then he said, quite quietly, with what breath he had:

“Ah.”

And he looked over her shoulder, past her, at the barred door under the quarterdeck.

“Cut the boy’s throat.”

*
**

She came up off the deck at him — not standing; lunging, all of it from the hips and the one good leg, with the axe going out low and flat.

And she did not take the leg.

She took the *hole*. The one she had put in him from a boat in the dark forty yards out, that he had been holding shut with one hand for five minutes because he is a man who does not believe in armour.

The axe went in where his hand was and took the hand with it.

He went flat. There was a moment where he was looking at the mast, and then there was not anybody looking at anything.

The two guards saw it happen from four feet away.

That was the second thing that night that stopped a fight. The first was the noise she made coming over the rail. Blau was the reason those men were still standing in formation on a deck they had already lost, and now Blau was a shape on the boards with an old woman lying next to him.

One of them stepped back.

*
**

“MAGDA — DOWN!”

She was already down. She got flatter.

Whatever Gardwen had been saving came down the length of that deck. You do not see it; you feel the deck go cold and wet in a rush from bow to stern — and the entangle took the whole waist of the ship. Cordage, weed off the rigging, wet rope coming alive off the pins and going round ankles and wrists and throats.

It caught both guards. It caught three knights forward. It caught two canal men who would be very rude about it later.

And it caught the knight at the door, with the beam half out of the brackets, two feet from a boy behind it.

CHAPTER 21 — TWO VOICES, ONE THROAT



THE BOY DOES NOT HAVE A NAME AND HAS NOT HAD ONE FOR TEN YEARS, WHICH IS not the same as having forgotten it, and is worse.

They call him nothing. That is the honest description of it. The dressing-man says *hold still* and the razor-man says *other side* and the one who brings the bowl does not speak at all, and the knights outside the door refer to him, on the rare occasions when they refer to him, as *it*.

He is seventeen. He is thin the way people are thin when somebody else decides what they eat. The whole upper left of his chest is a long-healed, re-opened, re-healed, re-opened mess, a wound that has been made and remade in the same place four hundred times, and it is the only clock he has.

And there is a man in him.

*
**

They are not friends and it would be obscene to say so, but they have been in one room for a decade and there is a kind of arrangement.

The man is a soldier. That is the shape of him. He is unfailingly, exhaustingly courteous, and he apologises, and he means it, and it does not help. When they open the boy in the mornings the man goes very quiet and stays quiet for hours afterwards, and the boy has

worked out that this is not weakness but a sort of withdrawal, the man taking himself as far away inside as he can go so that the boy can have the room to himself while it hurts.

When they make him fight, the man does it, and the boy is not there for that at all, which is the nearest thing to a mercy in his life.

And in between they argue.

That is what the crews hear through the deck and cannot stand: not screaming. *Arguing*. Two voices out of one throat having a row for hours, and one of them is a boy and one of them is not, and the one that is not sounds like a man being told to do something he thinks is dishonourable.

The morning cut is not only for the wear. It is to keep them tired. You bleed a man to keep him from arguing.

*
**

That night the ship changed its noise.

The boy noticed before anyone. He has nothing to do but notice. The hiss along the hull that has been there for five days stopped, all at once, and the cabin got colder by a degree, and the man in him came awake so fast that it hurt.

Something is happening.

Then the bell. Then the bell stopping, which was worse. Then a great deal of running about that was not the ordinary running about.

Then a noise from somewhere forward that neither of them had heard before, and the man — who has been in this boy for ten years and has, in that time, been enthusiastic about precisely nothing — said, in the boy's own head, with something the boy could only describe as *appetite*:

“Oh. Oh, that's the death-goddess. Listen to that.”

*
**

There were two of them in the cabin with him and neither was a soldier.

The one with the bowl was already backing into the corner with his hands up. The one with the razor was standing over the cot, and he had heard the order come down from the deck — *cut the boy's throat* — and he had not moved yet.

The boy watched him not move. He would like to be able to say he was brave about it. He was not. He was seventeen and tied into a routine and he lay there and watched a man decide whether he was the kind of person who does that, and he could not think of one single thing to say that would help.

Then the beam came out of its second bracket and the door went inward.

*
**

What came through it was an old woman.

She was in bloodied mail and she filled the doorway and she was screaming, and she had an axe, and there was something behind her on the deck that had recently been an extremely dangerous man.

The razor-man dropped the razor. It hit the boards and skittered under the cot. Then he sat straight down on the deck with his hands on his head — which was the single most sensible thing anybody did on that ship all night — and started saying *I only do the dressings, I only do the dressings* over and over.

And the boy said “*Don't—*”

And the man in him finished it, in a voice a thousand years older:

“— **she's not here for you.**”

*
**

The old woman pointed the axe at the razor-man and did not move.

The boy understood, later, that she was trying with everything she had not to close those eight feet, and that it was costing her more

than the fighting had. At the time it simply looked like an old woman shaking in a doorway making a noise through her teeth that was not words in any language.

And the man in him got an elbow under them and sat up, and the ruined chest moved, and he winced on the boy's behalf.

“Woman of the death-goddess.

“I have been listening to you come up this ship for a quarter of an hour. I know what you are and I know who sent you, and I have been waiting for somebody to come with that particular smell on them for a *very long time*.”

Then the boy's face contorted, because they were both trying to use one throat at once.

“— hurts, it hurts when he talks, *please* —”

“— I know. I am sorry. It will not be much longer now.”

And then, to her:

“Get us off this ship before the other one comes back with my bones.”

She got two words out. Ground through her teeth. Not a greeting and not a promise — the acknowledgement one soldier gives another across a yard.

“General Thuban.”

And the man in him said, with something like relief:

“Ah. Good.”

Then she turned round and went back out onto the deck, because that was where the rest of them were, and the boy did not see the next minute and the man did, and the man did not describe it to him, then or ever.

*
**

Some time after that a woman came and stood in the doorway and did not come in.

She had a staff in her hand and she had one hand on the frame and she stood there for about a minute and a half.

The boy did not know who she was. He wants that understood. He looked at a stranger of about twenty-one in woodland leathers and felt absolutely nothing at all, and was ashamed of it, and could not help it.

Do you know her? the man asked. Not out loud. He can do that.

No.

Look again.

And it was the man who worked it out, because the man has a thousand years of faces and the boy has ten years of a cabin, and what the man said next he said gently and out loud so that she would hear it too, and it was short, and afterwards the boy's whole face changed.

Then the man did the last generous thing available to him.

He stepped back.

He took himself as far away inside as he could go and gave the boy the room, the way he does in the mornings, except that this time it was not so that a child could be hurt privately.

And the boy's mouth moved.

What he said was one word, and it was not her name, because he was seven when they took him and there are things a seven-year-old calls a big sister that are not a name.

Her legs went. She caught herself on the edge of the cot and then she just put her forehead down on his shoulder — carefully, on the right, away from the wound — and stayed there, and he got one arm up around her head, and neither of them made any sound that carried as far as the door.

A wolf came over the rail from somewhere, soaked, and poured herself into that cabin and lay down under the cot without being asked.

And the man in him, from a long way off, said one thing more, and then nothing at all for the rest of the night:

“Good. Now hold on to that, because I am going to need you to be very brave tomorrow, and you have already been braver than anyone will ever tell you.”

CHAPTER 22 — YOU SAID TAKE THEM



RAVELLA ASKED FOR ONE THING BEFORE ANY OF IT AND MAGDA HAD SAID YES without much thinking about it, in a room at the Siren's Call, the way you agree to a price when your mind is on the goods.

Two dead men laid down properly, for one cold ship.

The Court had kept its half before she had done anything at all. When the temple boat came in on the south side of Lost Isle an hour before midnight, there were two shapes lying side by side on the stone under a sheet at the top of the cleared stair: Ellick Sarn, and the one she had put an axe through, brought up out of the drowned street by people who live down there.

She walked over to them on a bad leg with the axe still in her hand because she had forgotten she was holding it, and she knelt down on the wet stone, which hurt, and she pulled the sheet back off their faces, because she has never in her life said words over a covered face.

Behind her everybody stopped moving. Nerissa took her lamp two steps back. Under the stair the water went very still and it was not the wind that did it.

She said it.

"Mother of the darkness. Take these drowned back to their rest. It's time they went home."

And nothing happened.

The water stayed still. The lamps went on burning. The two men on the stone went on being two men on the stone and Ellick Sarn's face did not change in any way at all.

She waited. She gave it a good while, because she has stood at enough gravesides to know that the words sometimes take a minute.

They did not.

Somewhere down that stair, under the black water, something was *listening* and had not been given what it needed.

*
**

Ravella came and crouched on the other side of the bodies and looked at her across them, and she was not angry, which was worse.

"It's not the words," she said quietly. "The words were right."

"Then what?"

"You said *take them*." She laid two fingers on Ellick's forehead. "You're asking her to come and fetch. She won't. She never does — that's the entire nature of your goddess, isn't it? She takes the ones nobody sings about, and she takes them *when somebody finally brings them*."

She looked up.

"Your storyteller told you this and you were listening to the other half of it. Nobody ever came back for Thuban. Nobody has come back for *these two* either. Ellick's wife thinks he ran off, and that one's people don't know he's dead."

She stood.

"You have to do the part that costs you. Not ask her to take them. **Give them to her.** Say whose they are and say what was done to them and say that somebody came back — and you have to mean the last one, because you're the somebody."

Nerissa, from behind, very quietly: “That is exactly how it works, Magda. In every faith I know.”

And Hesper, who had been listening while he unpacked his bag, and who had gone rather pale:

“And if that’s the shape of it for two drowned boatmen who died last week...”

He did not finish it. He did not need to.

*
**

She muttered *I’m not a fucking priest* at the stone.

And then she did it anyway, kneeling on wet stone with a bad leg, in the voice you would use across a yard.

“Oi. Listen up then.

“Brothers, workers, toilers, men. You lived your lives as we all do — with imperfect plans, a little hope, a little selfishness, likely with much love and sadness when you died. In this place. In the water. The water that takes all things.

“But then these bastards brought you back. To haul, and work, and toil. Because it helped them.

“So fuck ‘em.

“Come with me, brothers. Rage with me at the loss and the death — and then go back to the dark deep sea. Go to your rest. Go now, my brothers. Go.”

She was, at this point, shouting at a hole in the ground.

*
**

The water at the foot of the stair did not part, and it did not glow, and it did not do any of the things a story would have it do.

It went *warm*.

That was all. It came up the steps past her knees like a draught from an open door in a cold house, and every lamp on that island bent toward it at once, and Nerissa made a small sound behind her.

And the two men on the stone let go.

There was no light. There was a *slackening* — she has seen it four hundred times in byres and beds and she would know it anywhere. Whatever was still holding the shape of Ellick Sarn's face stopped holding it, and what was left was just a boatman who died, and looked it, and looked *finished*.

The warmth went down the stair and took something with it.

Then the water was only water.

*
**

Nobody said anything for a while.

Ravella had both hands flat on the stone and her head down, and she stayed like that a long time. When she got up her face was wet and it was not canal water.

"They're through. The Court has them."

She looked at Magda and for once there was no broker anywhere in it.

"You said whose they were. Nobody has said whose anybody was down here in four hundred years."

And Hesper, staring:

"Magda. That was two men who died *last week*, and it took everything you had."

Out on the black water, north-east, one of Ravella's people whistled once. Low, two notes.

A small boat. One man. Something heavy amidships.

"Shut up, old man," said Magda. "Give me a drink so I can get ready for the next."

CHAPTER 23 — MIGHT COME IN HANDY



HE CAME ROUND THE EASTERN POINT WITH ONE SET OF OARS, UNHURRIED, NO lantern, and along the drowned street with the confidence of a man who has done it four times before, and he landed exactly where Ellick had landed his, and shipped the oars, and stepped out into the water without a sound.

He was a long time getting the thing out of the boat. It took him three tries and a great deal of care.

Oiled cloth, roped, about five feet long. He carried it up the drowned street on his shoulder with his back bent under it and set it down on the stone at the foot of the stair — *gently*, the way you set down somebody sleeping — and stood there breathing.

Then he said, to nobody, in a voice that carried beautifully across still water:

“Ellick. Get up here and help me with him.”

Nerissa did not even signal. She said, quietly, “*Take him*,” and the wall came alive, and four Swords came over it at once and two more out of the water behind him, and he was face-down on the stone with a knee in his back before the echo of *Ellick* had finished coming off the far wall.

He did not struggle. He did not shout.

He turned his head sideways against the stone, and what he did was *look*. At the shuttered lamps coming open one by one. At twelve Swords of the Lake. At Nerissa. At Hesper.

And then at the oiled bundle lying eighteen inches from his face, which he had set down so carefully, and which he was now not going to be allowed to touch again.

He was younger than anyone expected. Late thirties. Unremarkable in the way Crowbill is unremarkable, except that Crowbill chose it and this man was simply born with it. Ink on two fingers.

Hesper crouched over the bundle and did not touch it either. He looked at the ropework for a long moment — the way it was tied, what it was tied with — and his mouth thinned.

“That’s a *reliquary* knot,” he said. “That’s not how you tie cargo. That’s how you tie something you’re afraid of.”

*
**

They asked him.

He answered exactly three questions and they were all the wrong ones.

Is that Thuban Eta in the cloth? — “Yes.” *Will the removal work at this stair?* — “Yes.” *Will you tell us how?* — “No.”

And then he settled his shoulders against the wall and stopped.

Hesper tried for a long while, and he is good at it, and he went at it from underneath, professional to professional — *you’ve done this and I haven’t and I’d very much like to know how the seat is kept clean* — and you could see the man enjoying it, and enjoying not answering more.

At the end he said one thing unprompted, almost kindly:

“You’ll open him at the wrong point and put a thousand-year-old knight into a priestess. I’d rather like to see that.”

Nerissa stepped back from him and looked like she wanted to wash.

And then Hesper stopped mid-word with his hands coming away from his face and looked over Magda's shoulder at a tower-stub where a druid was sitting with her arm round a seventeen-year-old boy.

"Magda. We have been extraordinarily stupid.

"There is a man not thirty feet from us who has been *inside* one of these for a thousand years. Who was put in by experts and has had every day since to feel exactly how the seat is fastened.

"Why are we asking the gaoler? **Ask the prisoner.**"

*
**

Magda's answer to that was to start undoing buckles.

Nobody said anything for the first few, because everyone assumed it was the leg, or the fatigue, or the fact that she had been in mail since dawn.

The kettle helm went on the stone. Then the coif, and her hair came out flat and grey and wet. Then she went at the hauberk, which is a two-person job at the best of times, and Nerissa — who had been watching with a deepening frown — came and took the weight of it without being asked, and the two of them got it off over her head, and it went down on the stone with the noise a hauberk makes, which is like a great deal of money being dropped.

She was in a soaked wool shirt, in the cold, seventy years old, with a spear-hole in her thigh, standing on a drowned island in the dark.

Hesper had gone very quiet. Nerissa said, "Magda." And then, when she did not answer, she looked at the black water at the foot of the swept stair — water they had put a man into, in his mail, with his hands tied — and you could watch her arrive somewhere she did not like.

"*Magda.*"

She was going to beat him out of the boy. Unarmed and unarmoured and in the rage, the only way she knows how to do anything, and she went to the tower-stub and said so to his face.

*
**

And Thuban Eta said no.

The boy's face was wet and frightened and seventeen. Then it changed — you could watch it happen by then, the way you watch someone step forward in a doorway — and the other one was looking out. He took his time. He looked at her bare arms, and the spear-hole, and the axe she had left thirty feet away on the stone.

“No.”

A pause.

“But I understand why you thought of it, and I want you to know I would have taken that offer from you gladly, if it worked.

“Understand what you are proposing. You would beat me out of a child. **I do not feel your hands, woman. He does.** You would break his ribs and I would watch, and at the end of it I would still be here, because I am not held in his body by his body.

“They have been cutting him open every morning for ten years to do exactly what you just described. If pain could shift me I would have been shifted four hundred times.”

He let that sit.

“Now hear the rest, because you were closer than your priest is.

“There *is* a fight. You were right about that. But it is not yours, and it is not with the boy.

“They did not fasten me in with iron. Your storyteller told you and he was correct — **they fastened me in with the night I died.** Every hour I have spent in here I have spent back on that boat with my hands tied, going over the side, looking up at Corran and Vey and the rest of them not doing anything.

“That is the room I have been kept in. Not this child. *That.*”

The old voice went thin.

“And I cannot leave it, because to leave it I have to accept that it happened and that nobody came, and I have not been *able* to accept that, because it is unbearable, and I have had a thousand years of finding it unbearable.

“So. You do not need to fight me out. **You need to come and get me out of that water. Say it was wrong. Say whose I am. Say somebody came.**

“And you must mean it, and I will know if you don’t, because I have had a very long time to learn what people mean.

“Open my bones and open your door. And then stand where they stood, and do not look away when I go under, because they did.

“That is all it ever needed. It has only ever needed one person to turn up.”

*
**

So she went and got her grandmother’s country back out of wherever it had been sitting for fifty years, and it did not come as instructions. It came as smells. Woodsmoke and wet wool and somebody’s aunt weeping professionally.

You put his weapons back in his hands. A man goes out armed, and whatever was taken off him when he died is given back, and if you have not got it you give him yours, and that is better anyway.

You say the name. Out loud. First. Before anything, so that everyone standing there has to hear it.

Then you tell the tale. Not a prayer — a *telling*. Who he was and what he did and how he died, said in front of witnesses, in the open, at full volume.

You settle the debt. If a man was murdered somebody stands up and says so, and names it, and the wrong goes into the air where it can be heard. Nobody goes into the ground with an unpaid killing on him.

Then fire. Or water, for a drowned man. You give him back to whatever took him, on purpose this time, with people watching.

And then you feast, and you brawl, and you get disgracefully drunk, because a death that nobody celebrates is a death that did not count.

And then she hit the thing at the bottom of it, and it stopped her where she stood.

Valhalla is not his.

That is for the battle-dead. For the ones who fell with a sword in the hand and the enemy in front. Thuban Eta went over a gunwale in the dark with his hands tied by his own people. He was *cheated* of the death that buys that hall, and he has been paying for their crime with his afterlife for a thousand years.

Which is exactly, precisely, why he is Hel's.

And the wound is not the water and it is not the rope.

It is that in a thousand years, nobody has ever told his tale.

*
**

Hesper cut the reliquary knots, naming each one as it came off.

The oiled cloth came back.

Bones. Long ones, brown with age, laid the way you lay a man. And around the wrists, corroded almost to nothing but still there, still *on him* after a thousand years, two turns of iron wire.

They had put him in the water tied and nobody had ever cut it off.

Gardwen made a sound.

Nerissa said, "*Give me the shears*," and cut them, and dropped the wire in the water, and that alone changed the temperature of the air on that stair.

*
**

And then Magda did everything right and it was not enough.

She said the name. She put Vell's axe in the bones' hands. She stood at the head of the stair where his company had stood over him and said

the wrong out loud — *these men murdered you, and it was cowardice, and it was never answered for* — and she told his tale in a market-day voice to twelve Swords of the Lake and a priestess and a mage and a druid and a wolf and a whole Court listening from underneath.

It was the first telling he had ever had.

And she felt it not land. It is like putting your shoulder to a door that turns out to be a wall. Everything she had went into it and the world did not move an inch.

The water at the foot of the stair stayed cold. The lamps did not lean.

The boy on the stone started to shake, and the old voice came out of him ragged for the first time all night:

“— *I can't* — woman, I can't *reach* it, there's something across—”

Hesper was already up and moving. “The seat's still fastened. Something's still holding him and it is not the bones and it is not this stair—”

And the roped man against the wall, who had said nothing for twenty minutes, started to laugh.

It was a quiet, delighted, entirely genuine laugh.

“Oh, that's *good*. That's very good. You've done all of it properly and you've done it beautifully and you have forgotten one thing.

“He isn't only held by the bones.”

He tipped his head back against the stone, thoroughly enjoying himself.

“**The Baron wears the rest of him around his neck.** And the Baron is at the Governor's table three miles from here, being toasted.”

★

★★

She picked the axe up off the stone on the way past without breaking stride.

Say that again. Damn you. Explain. It. To. Me. Slowly. And fucking clearly.

He watched her come and he was *still* smiling, and then at about six feet he stopped smiling.

And then he did not flinch and he did not talk. What he did was look up at her with an axe six feet from his face and say, quite gently, like a man explaining something to a child at a funeral:

“You’re not going to. If you were, you’d have done it before you asked.”

And he closed his eyes and leaned his head back against the stone and was simply *done* with the conversation, and there was nothing behind that face she could reach with a weapon.

Hesper gave her the explanation anyway, because he did not need the prisoner for that part. The bones are the primary anchor. The locket is the working one, the piece they carry, the one the daily ritual runs through. It is not a spare. It is the *latch*. They cut a piece off him a century ago and every morning they use it to hold the seat shut.

“So the door is open. The bones are open. He is *willing* — you did that, and it worked, and I want you to hear that it worked.

“But there is a lock on this and it is around Hanzo di Teufel’s neck.”

Nerissa, into the silence: “The Tourney is at noon.”

And Gardwen, with her brother shaking against her: “Then that’s where we go. Because that’s where *he’ll* be. In the Governor’s box, in front of the whole city, wearing my brother round his neck.”

*
**

Magda did not join the strategising.

She stood at the edge of it with the axe hanging from one hand and watched the roped man, and he knew she was watching, and after a while he opened his eyes and looked back, and the two of them held that for a long time while everybody else worked out how to get into a Governor’s box at noon.

Nerissa was saying “—then Emeric has to hear it from Sana herself, and not in an anteroom—”

And she walked over and did it.

It took one.

The sound afterwards was the sound of everyone on that island stopping at once.

She found a grain sack by the stair, tipped out what was in it, put the head in, knotted the top, and said it to nobody in particular:

“Might come in handy.”

*

**

Corvin — twenty-two, who had taken a rope out to that island for her the night before — turned round and walked twenty feet away and was sick against a wall.

Hesper closed his eyes. Just for a moment. Then he opened them and went back to the bones, because he is a practical man and there was work, and he did not look at her again for some time.

Ravella did not react at all. She looked at the body, and then at the water, and said quietly to one of hers: “Not that one. He doesn’t go down there.”

Gardwen looked at her for a long moment. She did not say *why did you do that*.

She said: “Was he still worth anything?”

And Nerissa came and stood in front of her. Her face was perfectly still and her voice did not rise, and every Sword on that island could hear her.

“He was bound. On my island, under my cordon, taken by my people who had orders to hold him.”

She let that sit.

“And he was the only living soul who knew where **Bettan** is. Fourteen years old. Cheerful. Cutting girls’ hair at a school on the Northern Isles for people who fill them up.”

Her hands were shaking slightly and she was doing nothing to hide it.

“I gave you a reason to stop, once, and you took it. So I will not pretend I did not know what you were.

“But you have just taken that child away from me and I do not know how to get her back.”

She turned and walked away toward the boats.

Twelve Swords of the Lake watched her go, and then looked at Magda, and none of them said anything at all.

*
**

It was Gardwen who found the way round it, and she did it by putting the sack out of her mind, because there was a job.

She could not track a girl through a city with no ground. But she had found two men on Lost Isle from four hundred yards across open water without ever seeing them, because she had not been looking for men. She had been feeling for what was *in* them.

“Bettan’s been filled. If she’s carrying one of those things then she doesn’t read like a girl any more, and I don’t have to find *her*. I have to stand somewhere near that school and ask what’s *wrong* in it.”

She met Magda’s eye and did not soften it.

“I’d need Nerissa. Who has just walked off to the boats and will not want to look at you.

“Go and tell her anyway. Not sorry — she’d smell that. Tell her you’ve got a way to find the girl, and let her decide what she does with you afterwards.”

*
**

So Magda shouted “Oi. Priestess!” across a drowned street at the High Priestess of the Lake Lady, and walked over, and said it, and did not apologise, because she was not.

Don't look for the girl. Look for the demon. Gardwen can do it for you if you put her in the right place. Spare me your delicacies and so-called purities. The rot's in your city and it's not going to leave because you ask it nicely.

Nerissa listened to the whole thing without interrupting.

Then:

“You’ve mistaken me.”

Very level.

“I did not object because it was *unclean*. I have buried men off the tide-flats with their throats opened by people I then had to bless at Solstice. I’m sixty-one and I run a temple in a port.”

She took a step closer.

“I objected because you cut up the only map to a fourteen-year-old girl and then said *might come in handy*.

“That isn’t purity, Magda. **That’s arithmetic.**”

She held her eye until she was sure it had landed, and only then did the rest of her arrive, because she had already been thinking about the thing Magda had actually come to say.

“—and yes. Yes, that would work. I can put my hands in the water at Corbie’s and hold the channel for her the way I did last night, and if that child has something in her then it will show like a lamp through a shutter.” Her jaw tightened. “It’s better than anything I had, which was *ask the school again and hope*.

“We go at first light. Not before — the girls will be at breakfast and I want them in one room and counted while it’s done.”

Then, as Magda turned to walk away:

“Magda.” Not raised.

“I will work with you until this is finished, and I will do it wholeheartedly, and I will not pretend at you afterwards. When the boy is out and the Baron is down, you and I are done, and you will not be welcome on Temple Isle.”

A beat.

“Sword-Captain Vell’s axe stays with you. She’d have wanted that and I’m not petty.”

She got in the boat.

Magda shrugged at her back.

“No. I killed him because he deserved it. Fucker wasn’t going to tell you anything anyway. I don’t even know what arithmetic is.”

“No,” Nerissa agreed. “You don’t.”

*
**

At first light, at Corbie’s, with forty girls in a refectory being counted and treating it as an outrage, Nerissa went into the channel to her knees and Gardwen took her hand and put the other flat on the wall of the school.

It took about four seconds.

“There,” she said.

Then, immediately: “No. Wait—”

And her grip tightened hard enough to make the priestess wince.

“There’s **three**.”

Bettan, fourteen, cheerful, in the refectory with the others. And two more in that room. Girls who went quiet for a week sometime in the last month, and came back lovely, and started asking everyone about their families.

Nobody had noticed. Why would they? A homesick child getting happier is the thing you *want* to see.

“Magda — Santo had five twists of hair. He’d used one. Four left, and Sana’s was one of them.” Gardwen was grey. “They weren’t collecting *vessels*. They’ve been **filling** them. Here. For a month. In a school full of forty girls, four hundred yards from that stair.”

Nerissa came up out of the water very slowly.

“The four twists were the ones they hadn’t done yet,” she said.

She looked at the lit windows of the refectory, where forty girls were being counted and complaining about it.

“Then how many *have* they done?”

CHAPTER 24 — THE LAKELADY'S JAVELIN



TEMERACH NEBULO HAS BEEN TRYING TO PUT HANZO DI TEUFEL IN FRONT OF A magistrate for four years and has, in that time, accumulated letters, witnesses who recant, and two dead informants.

That is the whole of her career at present. She is aware of how it sounds.

She was sitting on an upturned crate in the competitors' enclosure at the Lake Lady's Tourney with her bow across her knees, doing nothing at all — which, people are always surprised to discover, is the entirety of her preparation. She is entirely still and she is not thinking about anything. It works.

She had not looked at the Governor's box once, which was remarkable, because everybody else on that field had.

She did not know that a ship had gone down in the Mouth. She did not know that Blau was dead, or that a seventeen-year-old boy was in a cell under the temple she could see from where she was sitting, or that her Order's High Priestess had spent the night on a drowned island cutting thousand-year-old wire off a dead knight's wrists.

The enclosure is sealed from the first horn. No messages in, no messages out. Nobody through the rope but judges and the Lady's own. It is not a Governor's rule; it is a temple rule and it is four

hundred years old and it exists precisely so that nobody can nobble a competitor with news from outside.

Nerissa wrote it. Or her predecessors did. She enforces it.

So there had been a young Sword standing at the cordon since first light with a folded note in his hand and the face of a man failing, and Temerach had not seen him, because she was not looking at anything.

*

**

The woman who came and stood in front of her was in a novice's vestment about a foot too long, and was seventy years old, and had canal on the hem, and moved like somebody who had fought yesterday and slept badly.

Temerach looked up.

She said four sentences. They were: we've rescued Thuban and the boy. Di Teufel was possessing people with demons all over the place. I just need the Baron's locket to complete the rite and lay the haunt to rest.

That is three. The fourth was *he's in a cell under the colonnade*, and it came later.

Temerach does not react the way people react. There was no start and no *what*. She took it in and filed it, and then she asked the two questions that mattered to her, in order.

"Is Conall alive?"

"Who?"

And that stopped her. Properly stopped her — the first thing all day that had.

"Conall Bjornlasch." She was watching the old woman's face now and getting nothing, because there was nothing there to get. "Dark. Twenty-two. Rides with me. He's been in this city three days."

"Never heard the name in my life, lass."

Something happened behind Temerach's composure that she did not intend and could not have described.

"...Then you don't know," she said slowly. "None of you know. You've spent three days pulling this apart and nobody has mentioned him once."

"That is either very good news or the worst news I've had this week, and I don't yet know which."

Then she put it aside — visibly, the way she does everything — and looked past her across the ground at the canopied box and the man in dragon-green.

It was the first time all day she had looked at him. Her face did not change at all.

"Later. The locket first. Tell me what it looks like, and how close you need to be."

*
**

She thought about the plan for perhaps four seconds, which for her is a long deliberation.

"Not in the box."

She said it as settled fact.

"Six thousand people are watching that canopy. If he dies in it, or is *taken* in it, then by tonight the story is that the temple and the Governor murdered a foreign lord at the Lady's own Tourney, and the three men sitting beside Emeric will make sure it's the only story. I have watched that happen to better cases than this one."

"So we don't go to him. **We make him leave.**"

"The Single Combat is called at the second hour. His champion is in a cell under that temple. He does not know it yet. So at the second hour a herald calls for the di Teufel man, and calls again, and *nobody comes* — in front of every Guild in this city."

“He will have about a minute to decide whether he is a man whose champion is late or a man who has been robbed. And he is not stupid. He’ll know.

“And then he leaves that box. He has to. He’ll go for his boat, and the only water-stair from the Governor’s enclosure is the one behind the colonnade, which is twelve feet wide with a wall on one side.

“That’s where he can be taken, and it is out of sight of the ground, and everything that happens there happens in front of temple witnesses instead of the whole city.”

She was stringing the bow while she talked. She did not look at what her hands were doing.

“A magician. Yes, I’d assumed. Which is why he does not get a minute of warning and does not get his hands free.”

Then she looked at the old woman properly, and there was something almost like humour in it.

“And you’re the part I can’t do. He will leave when the herald calls. Or he will leave *sooner*, and on our timing instead of his, if somebody he does not know walks up to that box and shows him something that tells him it has all already gone wrong.”

A pause.

“You’ve been carrying that sack since you got here.”

*
**

“It’s the quiet one’s head,” said the old woman. “He was pissing me off. I was told you wouldn’t be OK with that but it’d definitely get the good Baron’s attention.”

Temerach’s face did not change at the word *head*.

“I am not going to pretend that pleases me.” Flat. “But I have seen what that man’s people do to fourteen-year-olds and I am not going to stand on a field and lecture you about a demonologist’s neck.

“Use it if it works.”

And then the old woman asked whether Conall was any good with a bow.

“No,” Temerach said.

Much too fast.

The old woman waited.

“He’s —” She was stringing something that was already strung. “He has a soldier’s training, all weapons. He’s competent. He’s not an archer.”

“That’s not what I asked, lass. I asked if he was any good.”

“He’s *competent*.”

*
**

Here is a thing about Temerach Nebulo which she is aware of and has never been able to do anything about. She is one of the most dangerous people in this realm and she is an appalling liar. She has no facility for it whatsoever.

She had just told an old woman she met four minutes earlier two things she had no intention of telling anybody: that Conall is a great deal better than competent, and that she would rather chew her own hand off than have him within a mile of that box.

She heard herself do it, too.

“He is my responsibility,” she said, more carefully. “He is twenty-two, he came to this city because I brought him, and there is a reason I have kept him away from the di Teufels that I am not going to discuss on a competition field with a woman I met four minutes ago.

“Ask me again tonight and I may tell you. Ask me now and I’ll say no and mean it.”

Then, briskly, closing it:

“The Archery is called in a quarter of an hour. I will be on that line for the better part of an hour and I cannot leave it without forfeiting

— and I want to win it, because the prize is court access and that is *four years* of my work.

“So you have an hour where I am the most visible person in Purewater and can do nothing at all.

“Use it. Get me one thing: whether he still has the locket on him. If he’s left it on a ship or in a strongbox we are all wasting the afternoon.”

*

**

The Archery runs in three passes and by the third there were four of them left.

First pass, fixed targets at eighty paces. She hit everything and the crowd did not notice her, because everybody hits at eighty paces.

Second pass, moving targets on boats poled across the gap between the islands.

That is when six thousand people found out who she was.

The boats go across left to right at a walking pace with the targets standing on them, and the field is allowed six shafts. The Guild man ahead of her put four in and the ground was very pleased with four.

Temerach shot six.

She does not track. That is the thing you notice from the rail. Everyone else swings the bow with the boat. She does not. She puts the bow where the boat is *going to be*, and waits, and looses, and the target arrives at the arrow.

Six shafts. Six hits. The last two into the same target inside a handspan while the boat was at its furthest and fastest.

The noise the ground made was not applause. It was the noise people make when they have been shown something.

Third pass, cross-channel, two hundred and fifty paces over open water with the wind off the Mouth. She and the Guild archer both came through it, and he is genuinely good, and on any other day in any other year he wins that and dines out on it for a decade.

Today he was standing next to somebody who had put two arrows into the same moving target at range and then apologised to the judges for the grouping.

They called it for Temerach Nebulo, Knight of the Swords of the Lake. A purse, a silver bracer, and access to the Governor's court.

*
**

There was one window to warn her and it was a good one, and it did not work.

Nerissa was to present the prize. It is her Tourney and they are her Order's colours and the High Priestess handing a Sword of the Lake her bracer in front of the city is the most ordinary thing that happens all afternoon. Four words, while she does it. *Box coming. He has it.*

She was three steps from the dais with the bracer in her hands when a man in Governor's livery came down the steps and took it out of them.

Vosk. The chamberlain who had kept Lilura in an anteroom for four hours.

He did it beautifully. A small bow, a murmured word about the Prince wishing to honour the champion of the Archery *personally*, and it is protocol, and it is correct, and there is not one thing the High Priestess of the Lake Lady can do about it in front of six thousand people without making a scene that the three men beside Emeric would enjoy enormously.

She stood there with empty hands.

Emeric — who is twenty-four and did not understand what had just been done with him — presented the bracer himself, delightedly, and said something complimentary about the second pass.

Temerach received it, bowed, and was invited to stay in the canopy.

She had no idea what was coming.

Four feet to her left, a man in dragon-green was being handed a fitted wooden case by a steward, with a note in it written by a woman who learned to write late.

CHAPTER 25 — A DREADFUL PLACE TO FIGHT A MAN LIKE ME



THE BOX HAD BEEN BOUGHT OFF A CHANDLER FOR MORE THAN IT WAS WORTH: A fitted wooden case with a sliding lid, the sort a merchant sends samples in.

The note took a while, because Magda writes like a woman who learned late.

***YOUR SHIP IS ON THE BOTTOM. YOUR MAN IS DEAD.
I HAVE YOUR CHAMPION AND HIS BONES. — THE PIG
WOMAN***

Gardwen read it over her shoulder and said nothing for a while, and then:

“You’ve spelled *champion* wrong.”

“He’ll get the sense of it.”

*
**

Before that, there had been an hour of being an old woman at a fair, and it was excellent.

She bought fried fish and found a place on the public rail and watched the Archery, and for about an hour nobody in Purewater

wanted anything from her at all. It was the first hour like that in four days. She would like it recorded that she enjoyed every minute of it and that the fish was very good.

And Nerissa had put the Lady's cloth on her to get her through that rope, which had cost the priestess something and which she had said so, plainly, while she did it with her own hands.

"I am going to put the Lady's cloth on a woman who beheaded a bound prisoner on my island eight hours ago, and I am going to do it with my own hands, and I would very much like you to appreciate what that costs me."

Magda had kept her face absolutely straight. It cost her something too.

"Don't," said Nerissa, when it was done.

"Wasn't going to say a word."

"You were *radiating*."

*
**

Marisette had got the servants. Three of her girls had worked Tourney service for years and one of them — Corliss's youngest, eighteen, who has poured at four Tournes and is very good at being furniture — was in the Governor's enclosure that afternoon because she always is.

Nobody had to be told a story. Marisette said *look at what's round the Baron's neck and tell me* and they said *right you are*.

She went in with the wine four times over the hour and came out with this.

It is on him. Gold, a flattened oval about the size of a thumbnail, on a fine chain, worn under the shirt — but the chain shows at the collar and the shape of it shows through the green when he leans forward.

And he touches it. Not fidgeting. Every so often his hand goes flat to his chest over it, briefly, the way a man checks a purse. And once, when a Guildmaster leaned in to toast him, he moved his shoulder to put it further away.

“He does it about every quarter hour. And after he does it, he looks round.”

Then she told them the rest, and her hands were not steady.

“He caught me.”

Fourth pour. She was closer than she needed to be and she looked a half-second too long, and when she came back up he was already looking at her.

And he smiled. And said — pleasantly, in front of two Guildmasters and the Prince — “*You’ve very good hands, girl. Who do you serve?*”

She said the Guild steward’s name, because it is true.

He said: “*Of course.*” And went back to his cup.

“He wasn’t angry,” she said. “That’s what’s wrong with it. He was **pleased.**”

Marisette had her off the island and onto a boat before she told anybody, which is the correct order to do those two things in.

*
**

From a hundred and forty feet, Magda saw almost nothing, and that was the point.

He slid the lid. He looked down into the box for about two seconds. He slid the lid back.

He said something to the Guildmaster beside him and the Guildmaster laughed.

Then he set the case down beside his chair, stood, and made a small apologetic gesture to Prince Emeric — *forgive me, a moment* — and Emeric waved him away good-naturedly, and he stepped out of the back of the canopy with his cup still in his hand.

He did not hurry. He did not look round the ground once.

He is very, very good.

“Did he—” said Gardwen.

“He read it. He’s going for his boat.”

*
**

Down the public rail, through the fried-fish crowd, past the ale trestles, round the back of the colonnade where the ground gives way to worked stone and the noise drops off like a door closing.

The water-stair behind the Governor’s enclosure. Twelve feet wide, a wall on the left, the channel on the right, thirty-odd steps down to a landing where three boats were tied and two bored oarsmen were playing dice.

Out of sight of six thousand people.

She got there first, because she was closer and because he was being unhurried and correct.

Gardwen came down behind her and put herself flat against the wall inside the arch. Ruhi was somewhere above on the colonnade roof, which Magda had decided not to think about.

Footsteps in the passage. Unhurried. One set.

Then a second set, quicker, catching up. “*My lord — my lord, the herald’s calling the Single Combat—*”

And Hanzo di Teufel said, perfectly pleasantly, from fifteen feet the other side of the arch:

“Yes. Tell them my champion withdraws. Injury in training.”

A pause.

“And find out who delivered that box.”

*
**

She loaded flat against the wall inside the arch with the vestment sleeve pushed up out of the way. Stone in the pouch, cord round the knuckles, staff cocked back along the forearm.

The servant’s footsteps went away up the passage.

His did not.

He came through the arch. Close to, Baron Hanzo di Teufel is a well-made man of about fifty in dragon-green with grey at the temples and very good boots, and the cup was still in his left hand, and he had not spilled a drop of it.

He was looking at the boats.

He got three steps down before he registered that there was an old woman in a Lake Lady novice's vestment standing against the wall with a loaded staff sling.

He stopped.

He looked at her for a moment — at the vestment, at the sling, at her face — and she watched him do arithmetic a great deal faster than the serving girl had.

"Ah," he said.

And then, with what sounded like genuine warmth:

"The pig woman."

He had not put the cup down.

"You've cost me a great deal in three days and I would very much like to know how you did the ship. I'll pay for that answer, and I pay well." He tilted his head slightly. "Or we can do the other thing, and you should know before you choose that you are standing on wet stone at the bottom of a walled passage, which is a *dreadful* place to fight a man like me."

Behind him, in the arch, unhurried, blocking it, Temerach Nebulo had an arrow already on the string.

Magda spat on the step between them.

"Hel's waiting for you, Baron. Time you went down."

*
**

He threw himself sideways and he is quick for fifty and the stone found him anyway.

It took him high in the chest and turned him completely round, and the cup went out of his hand and shattered on the step, and he landed badly on wet stone and came up on one elbow with his court silk torn open and a bruise the shape of a fist coming up underneath it.

And now he was not warm and he was not amused.

He got a hand up — palm out, fingers spread, and she had seen exactly that once before, at a ford, when a druid asked a favour of the water — and the air in that passage went *dry*.

“MAGDA—” from the arch.

And behind him, from the top of the stair, absolutely calm:

“My lord Baron. Put the hand down.”

“You are under arrest by warrant of the Order of the Lake Lady for the profanation of the Tourney and the sacred channel. There are two Guildmasters and a Prince forty feet above us.

“I have been trying to say those words to you for four years.

“Put the hand down.”

He was on the steps between an old woman with a loaded sling and the finest archer in the realm.

His hand did not go down.

*
**

He was prone and unarmoured and he had chosen to finish the spell rather than defend himself, because he is a man who has never once been hit by anything.

She did not throw the staff. She went down the three steps with it held short in both hands like a woman going at a rat in a grain store, and brought the end of it down on the wrist.

There was a crack that was mostly the staff and partly not.

The hand shut.

And whatever had been gathering in that passage — the dry, tight, wrong feeling of air being *asked* for something — came apart all at once with a sound like a held breath being let go, and the temperature came back, and somewhere above them a gull started complaining again.

Hanzo di Teufel made a noise through his teeth. It was the first entirely honest sound he had made in three days.

He cradled the arm against his chest and looked up at her from the wet stone with his hair come loose and his silk torn and a stone-bruise spreading under it.

Fifty years of never once being touched, undone on a service stair by an old woman with a stick.

“You *hag*—”

*
**

And then his left hand — the good one — moved very slightly toward his own collar.

She slapped it down out of the air like a woman swatting a wasp off a pie.

Then she took a fistful of green silk and collar and chain, all together, and put her face about four inches from his.

And she did not rip it. Not straight away.

She held him there, eye to eye, on the wet stone, and let him get a proper look at what had been coming up that stair for him — which is not a knight and not a priestess and not a magistrate. It is an old woman who keeps pigs, sent by a goddess he has never once thought about, wearing a novice’s vestment she has no right to, with fried fish on her breath.

He stared back and he was, for the first time, entirely out of arithmetic.

Then she pulled.

The chain did not break at the clasp. It broke across the back of his neck, and it took skin, and he cried out.

And it came away in her fist: gold, a flattened oval about the size of a thumbnail, warm — *properly* warm, the warmth of something that has been alive against a chest for a hundred years — and a great deal heavier than a thing that size has any right to be.

Inside it, something moved.

Not rattled. *Moved*.

*
**

He went very still underneath her.

And then, in a voice that had lost every bit of its charm:

“You have no idea what you are holding. You cannot *open* that, you stupid woman, if you open that here he will go into the nearest—”

“**I know.**”

That was Hesper, standing in the arch at the top of the stair with his bag, entirely out of breath, having run the length of the colonnade.

“She’s not going to open it here.”

Temerach came down and put a boot between the Baron’s shoulders and got his good arm behind him, and it was over, and it had taken about ninety seconds.

Above them, six thousand people were being told that the di Teufel champion withdrew through injury, and there was a certain amount of booing.

*
**

Hesper took the locket in a folded cloth and did not touch it with his skin, and put it in a box within a box, and his hands were not quite steady.

“Bones, door, and the latch,” he said. “That’s all three. For the first time in a hundred years, all three are in one place.”

And Magda, who had been waiting an hour to say it, told Temerach about the second pass. Six shafts, six hits, two into the same target at the furthest and fastest, and the apology to the judges.

One of the most beautiful things I've seen in my life. And I'm a lot older than I look.

And the finest archer in the realm, who had just arrested the man she had hunted for four years and who had a knee on him at the time, went completely to pieces for about a second and a half. She went pink to the ears and looked at the step and said:

“The sixth was high.”

“It was in the target.”

“It was *high*.” Firmly.

Then, quieter, and clearly having to make herself do it:

“...Thank you. That's a kind thing to say and I never know what to do with them.”

And she hauled the Baron up onto his knees.

CHAPTER 26 — SOMEBODY CAME



NERISSA LOOKED AT THE CHANNEL AS THEY CAME DOWN THE TEMPLE STAIR AND SAID “*it’s thin*,” in the voice of a woman reporting a fact she wishes she could not feel.

It took forty minutes to get everything to Lost Isle.

The boy, carried, awake, and very frightened. Gardwen beside him the whole way with her hand in his. Ruhi in the bottom of the boat. Hesper with a box within a box. Nerissa, who had left her own Tourney running behind her without a backward glance. Twelve Swords. And Ravella, with four of hers in the water alongside the whole way, which no boatman in that city has ever had happen to them.

The drowned street. The swept stair. The bones laid out on the stone with the wire cut off the wrists and a borrowed axe across them.

Hesper set the locket down at the head of the bones and opened the outer box and then, with a great deal of care, the inner one.

The thing inside it moved.

*
**

They put the boy down on the stone at the top of the stair, and Gardwen held him, and Thuban Eta came up into his face for what everybody there understood was the last time.

He looked at the bones. Then at the locket. Then at Magda.

“You came back,” he said.

“Aye.”

“Then I am ready, and I have been ready for a thousand years, and I would like you to be quick — because he is very tired and I have taken enough of his life.”

*
**

She did it exactly as she had done it before, because it had been right before.

She said the name. **Thuban Eta**. Out loud, first, so that everyone on that rock had to hear it.

She told the tale — the valley he would not burn, the argument he won in front of men who killed him for it, the boat in the dark, the wire on the wrists, the water — in a market-day voice, to a priestess and a mage and a druid and a wolf and twelve Swords of the Lake and a whole Court listening from underneath.

She named the wrong out loud, so that it went into the air where it could be heard: *this was murder, and it was cowardice, and no one ever answered for it.*

And then she did the part that costs.

She went down two steps into the black water in a novice’s vestment she had no right to, up to her knees, and stood exactly where nine men had stood over a bound knight a thousand years ago and done nothing.

And she did not look away.

“You went in here and nobody came. I came. You’re not theirs and you’re not his and you were never Valhalla’s, because they cheated you of the death that buys it.

“You’re hers. You’ve always been hers. And she takes the ones nobody sings about — but only when somebody finally brings them.

“Mother of the darkness. This is Thuban Eta and I have brought him. He’s yours. Take him home.”

*
**

The locket opened on the stone by itself.

Not dramatically. It simply came apart, the way a shell does when whatever was holding it shut has stopped bothering.

And the water went warm.

It came up past her knees like a draught from an open door in a cold house, and every lamp on that island bent toward it at once, and under the surface something enormous and patient turned over and paid attention.

On the stone, the boy arched once against Gardwen’s arms and made a sound that was two voices, and then one voice, and then no voice at all.

And something went down that stair.

She did not see it. She *felt* it go past her in the water — unhurried, the way a big fish goes past your legs in a river — and there was a moment, exactly one, where she had the absolutely unmistakable sensation of being **looked at** by something that was grateful and was not going to say so, because it was a soldier.

Then it was gone.

The bones on the stone settled very slightly, the way bones do.

And the water was just water.

*
**

Silence.

Gardwen’s brother was limp in her arms with his eyes open. Breathing.

Then he said, in a boy’s voice with nobody behind it:

“...it’s quiet.”

*
**

Magda came up out of the water and her legs did not work properly and she did not much care.

She got to them on her knees on the wet stone and put her arms round both of them at once — the girl who had been carrying ten years of a dead brother, and the boy who had just had a thousand-year-old man taken out of him — and held on.

And then, after seventy years of not doing this in front of anybody, she came apart completely.

It was not graceful. It was the ugly kind, from the chest, the kind that hurts your throat. A great old woman in a stolen vestment howling on a rock in a drowned street with her face in a druid's hair and one hand knotted in a boy's shirt.

She had killed eleven people in two days. She has never been able to say whether that is what it was about. Probably it was not only that.

Gardwen got hold of her arm with her free hand and did not let go of it.

The boy did not understand who she was at all. He put his head against her anyway, because she was warm and because there was nothing left in him to do anything else with.

Ruhi shoved her whole head under her elbow and stayed there.

*
**

Nobody on that island said a word.

Nerissa turned her back. Not away from them — she turned and faced the others and *made them stop looking*, which is the single kindest thing she did all week.

Hesper sat down heavily on the step with the empty locket in his hands and stared at nothing.

Ravella went to the edge of the stair, and crouched, and said something down into the water that was not in any language anybody there knew — and something answered, and this time everybody heard it.

And Corvin — twenty-two, who had been sick against a wall for her — cried openly and did not bother to hide it.

*
**

It took a while.

When she finally got her breath the light had moved on the water, and the boy was asleep against Gardwen with his mouth open, and Gardwen had not moved a muscle in case it woke him.

She looked at Magda over the top of his head. Her face was absolutely wrecked and about ten years younger.

“Magda,” she said. “I don’t know his name.”

A pause.

“He was seven. We called him Bird. I don’t know what his *name* is.”

“Call him Bird, then.”

Gardwen looked down at him.

“It’d be a lot better than anything those bastards called him,” Magda said. “And he’ll pick his own when he’s ready. That’s how it works — you get given one, and then one day you take one.”

“Nobody’s given him anything since he was seven.”

She nodded, and did not trust herself to say anything, and put her cheek back down on the top of his head.

CHAPTER 27 — LONG LOST FAMILY



CONALL BJORNLASCH HAD BEEN IN A SMALL ROOM OFF THE TEMPLE'S SOUTH CLOISTER for an hour being told nothing, and he was not pleased about it.

He is quick. That is the trouble with him and always has been. He had already worked out that something enormous had happened in this city in the last three days and that he had been kept a mile away from all of it on purpose, and he had got as far as being angry and no further.

Then the door opened and Temerach came in with an old woman.

He did the whole of her in one pass, because that is what he does: the vestment she had no right to, the canal on the hem, the staff, the fact that she was moving like somebody who had fought yesterday and slept badly.

"You're not clergy."

"No."

"Temerach, what is this."

*
**

She did not sit down. She stood with her hands at her sides like a woman giving a report to a superior officer, which is the only register she has, and it turned out to be exactly the right one.

“Conall. I am going to tell you four things and then you may do whatever you like to me.

“**One.** Baron Hanzo di Teufel is your father. You were born of an elven mage he seduced and ruined, twenty-two years ago, and she fled to this city and died here.

“**Two.** You have a brother. A twin. He is somewhere in Purewater and he does not know about you either.

“**Three.** I have known both of those since before I took you in at nineteen. Every day since, I have chosen not to tell you.

“**Four.** He was arrested this afternoon, by me, on the water-stair, and he will be questioned tonight — and he will say all of this out loud in front of a magistrate to buy himself an hour. So you were going to hear it today whatever I did. I wanted it to be from me.

“That is not the same as it being *right*.”

And then she stopped. Completely. No softening, no *I'm sorry*, nothing.

*
**

He did not move for a long moment.

And because he is quick, he did not get to have the easy reaction. He went straight past *you're lying* and straight past *this can't be*, and landed on all the small things at once, and you could watch each one arrive.

That's why you found me at nineteen.

That's why we came to Purewater.

That's why you entered the Archery.

He put one hand flat on the table.

“How long have I been the reason?” he said. “For — any of it. All of it. The Order, the training, the—”

His voice went.

He looked up.

And he was not looking at Temerach. He was looking at the stranger. The one with no stake. The only person in that room who had nothing whatsoever to do with any of it.

“Is she telling the truth?”

*
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The old woman pulled the sash off over her head and dropped the whole vestment on the chair, and stood there in her own filthy shirt and ringmail, which answered his question about who was talking before she opened her mouth.

“Yeah. Course she is.”

That was all. She did not dress it and she did not explain it and she did not tell him it would be all right.

“Go find your brother.”

He stared at her.

“Where?”

“Don’t know. It’s your city, not mine.” A shrug. “But he’s got your face, so ask around. Someone’ll have seen it.”

*
**

Then, conversationally, to Temerach, while Conall was sitting down very suddenly:

“He’s better looking than Santo.”

Temerach made a small strangled noise.

“Huh,” said the old woman. “Does that make them the shitbird’s heirs, then? What’s that make you, lad — a Baronet?”

And Temerach answered it, because she has spent four years in law books.

“No. And yes. And that is the most dangerous thing in this room.”

She finally sat.

“Bastards do not inherit. Not in the border law and not here — that’s clean. But Santo di Teufel was the only legitimate issue, and Santo is dead, and if Hanzo is attainted for desecration and demon-craft then the barony and the tower and everything in it goes back to the Crown to dispose of.

“And when a Crown disposes of a border holding, it looks for **blood**. Not because bastards have a right. Because it’s tidier to hand a wild border march to somebody the local men will follow than to install a stranger and pay for a garrison for twenty years.”

She looked at Conall.

“So no, you are not his heir. But there are men in three counties who will hear *the di Teufel bastard* and start doing arithmetic — and there is a border tower full of a hundred years of that family’s work sitting empty tonight, and there is a movement of people who wanted a Dragon King badly enough to fund all of this, and **they have just lost their candidate**.

“You and your brother are going to be *extremely* interesting to some very bad people by the end of the month. Both of you. And neither of you has any protection at all except the Order and me.”

Conall said, hoarsely: “And him. He’s alive. He knows I exist now?”

“He will by tonight.”

*
**

While that was happening on Temple Isle, the High Priestess of the Lake Lady was standing on the temple steps at the close of the Tourney in front of the Governor, every Guild in Purewater, and six thousand people who had come for the Single Combat and got something considerably better.

She named the desecration. She named the arrest, by warrant, of Baron Hanzo di Teufel. She named the fouling of the sacred channel, and the fact that she rang the alarm and was told to stop — and she

looked directly at Prince Emeric's chamberlain when she said that part, and Vosk went the colour of paper.

And then she said the sentence she owed.

"The canal folk kept the Lady's water clean."

She said it slowly. She let it sit. And when the ground did not quite know what to do with it, she said it again, louder, and added:

"Say it back to me."

And six thousand people did.

Somewhere out on the water, a very forgettable man with a crow inked on the back of his hand heard an entire city say it, and nobody has ever found out what his face did.

*
**

The Moist Oyster, that evening, because Thorne is owed the true version once and because it is the only room in Purewater where a Guildmaster, a thief, a priestess and a wolf can all be in the same place and nobody will comment.

Constantine sent food she could not afford to send. Marisette sent wine nobody will ever be able to afford to drink again. Ravella came in through the water-door with four of hers, which stopped the room for a moment.

Ila was there because she had threatened Constantine with a very specific kind of hell, and she had attached herself to Bird — who was sitting in the warmest corner in three cloaks, eating steadily, saying almost nothing, with Gardwen on one side and a wolf across his feet.

Nerissa did not come. She sent Lilura, and a note, and a cask.

Hesper came late, from the school, and said the two shallow girls were out and sleeping, and did not say anything at all about the third.

And Thorne was in his corner with his chalk, watching the door.

*
**

At about the ninth bell, Asphodel came in with a young man behind her.

Dark. Twenty-two. Well-dressed in a way that was not his money.

He was halfway through saying something to her when he saw the man standing up at the far table — the one with his own face on him — and the sentence just stopped.

The whole room stopped with it.

Conall and Randall looked at each other across the Moist Oyster for the first time in twenty-two years.

Neither of them said anything.

And Thorne, very quietly, from his corner, to nobody at all:

“Oh, that’s good.”